

■ TRUST THE BASIS OF GOVT-PEOPLE RELATIONS; APPROACH IS 'PERMITTED UNLESS PROHIBITED'

■ REFORM EXPRESS IS GOING TO MOVE FASTER TOWARDS THE TARGET OF VIKSIT BHARAT

■ OUR POLICIES ARE PRO-PEOPLE, PRO-GROWTH, PRO-DEVELOPMENT AS PER NEEDS OF THE NATION

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Secure India a Harbinger of Stability Across World



Satyan Gajwani, chairman of Times Internet, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Our Political Bureau | New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi assured the nation on Friday that the government's "Reform Express" will power ahead at an even more rapid pace in the coming days and expressed confidence that the road to world stability will emerge from a secure, politically stable India.

Addressing an august gathering of captains of industry, heavyweights from domestic and international politics, and opinion makers at The Economic Times World Leaders Forum in the national capital, he asserted that his government has ensured both ease of living and ease of doing business, leading to upliftment

of the weaker sections of society.

India has been an oasis of political stability while the world has been going through ups and downs, the Prime Minister emphasised in a 40-minute address on Friday. He agreed with the forum's theme — *Shared Futures: Secure, Intelligent, Resilient* — and said, "Nothing exists in isolation." As nations grow increasingly interconnected, they should together strive to build a better tomorrow.

"In the coming days, ease of living and ease of doing business will expand further," he said. "This government will keep working continuously for the youth, Nari Shakti, farmers, poor and middle class. The 'Reform Express' is going to move forward at a faster pace. We will keep working continuously with full commitment for the target of Viksit Bharat."

India's role in the global economy will be a central one. "For me, if the future of Bharat is assured, then the path to the big task of world stability is going to emerge from this land," Modi said. "With the self-confidence that the more stable India becomes, its future becomes more secure, the strength to provide world stability will be created here."

He said resources have been weaponised, and the pervasive distrust poses several challenges. In this scenario, India is a bright spot, with more than 250 million people having been lifted out of poverty in the past decade. He cited the International Monetary Fund's forecast that India will remain the "fastest growing major economy" in the world.

The Prime Minister touched upon issues that concern the common people and how his government has tried to make their life easy. He recalled his Independence Day speech of last week and said the *saptadhara* — seven *shakti* or streams — will guide the nation towards becoming a developed country. These are manufacturing, technology, agriculture and food processing, green and blue economy, Gati Shakti and India's soft power.

Modi referred to his speech at last year's edition of ET WLF, where he had said reforms were not a compulsion but a commitment for his government.

Earlier, it was Production-Linked Punishment >> 7

'NATION CAN BE GROWTH ENGINE' India Inc's Got All It Takes to Roll Out 'World+I' Model

Global economy has shock absorbers for geopolitical stress, says KM Birla

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The global economy has developed strong shock absorbers to cope with a vastly greater order of stress, growing despite wars, a pandemic, interest rate hikes, tariff increases and energy jolts in the past few years, said Kumar Mangalam Birla, chairman, Aditya Birla Group.

"Growth has probably slowed down and all of us — economies, corporations — have learnt to deal with a lot more stress," said the head of one of India's biggest conglomerates at The Economic Times World Leaders Forum 2026.

"The biggest source of stress is geopolitics. And there too, the global order is changing," he said.

The Aditya Birla Group, which has a market capitalisation of \$118 billion, has taken a contrarian view during this period, expanding in new and traditional areas, he said, with businesses in India reflecting the underlying economy.

The group is currently in the midst of investments worth \$30 billion spanning its various divisions — metals, cement, telecom, renewable energy, green fibre and carbon black.

Birla dismissed the standard China+1 supply chain strategy, rejecting it as "intellectually lazy," calling instead on India Inc to adopt a "World+I" model. "We have all it takes, we have got a track record, and I think that we really can be a growth engine for the entire world," he said.

All large conglomerates in the country have been investing aggressively, Birla said, responding to rhetoric that the domestic capital expenditure cycle has been weak. "I don't think we should confuse capital discipline with conviction about India. I find that conviction about India is perhaps the highest I have seen for a long time," he said.

Kumar Birla, chairman, Aditya Birla Group

Investment in Ecosystems >> 7

Banks Raise \$12b Overseas on Swap Boost



Indian banks have already raised \$12 billion overseas this year, taking advantage of RBI's swap facility, and global appetite for local banking papers should help lenders raise even more funds ahead of the August 31 deadline, bankers said. Joel Rebello reports. >> 8

Welspun Bags Mega ₹17kcr Order for Pipes



Welspun Corp has secured its largest single order worth ₹17,200 crore (\$1.8 billion) for supply of pipes from its US facility, it said. This takes the company's global order book to a record \$4.4 billion, or about ₹42,100 crore. >> 7

Couples Opt for Off-track Weddings



Wedding planners and décor companies said they are seeing a 20-30% increase in bookings for locations beyond large cities, report Sneha Joseph & Alenjith K Johny. There are often looking for scenic places and personalised experiences. >> 3

Overview

TODAY'S WELLNESS SCORE

Ananaya Chopra 73

NUTRITION

SLEEP

5HR 4MIN



ACTIVE MINS

96



DOS & DON'TS

5/6



LIFESTYLE

Biomarkers

VITAMIN D

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YOUR VITAMIN D VALUE

SUB-OPTIMAL

30.8 ng/ml

NUTRIENTS



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HIGH-VOLTAGE SHOW AT PARLIAMENT STREET POLICE STATION

7 hr Sit-in by Rahul, Cong Brass, Pellet Victim Force Delhi Police to File FIR

FIR was filed against ‘unknown’ accused; Lok Sabha’s LoP hails the ‘first step of justice’

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Rahul Gandhi and other Congress leaders held a seven-hour sit-in with 19-year-old victim of alleged pellet gun firing, Sahil Lochab, and his mother at Parliament Street police station on Friday, prompting the police to finally file a first information report (FIR) late in the evening on Lochab’s complaint after refusing to do so for days.

The dharna was called off on a triumphant note thereafter, with Gandhi hailing the “first step of justice”, even as he alleged that “people at the top” had kept the police from registering the FIR on Lochab’s complaint about him suffering pellet injuries, allegedly during the July 20 police action against agitating students. The FIR was filed against “unknown” accused.

“This is the first step of justice. A case is lodged. It has been a month since the pellets hit his (Lochab’s) body and eyes. Injustice has been done to this youth. We came here around 11 am. Before that he had been going around for a month. An FIR has now been finally filed,” Gandhi told journalists, with Lochab and others flanking him. “Now you imagine how many women are raped in this country, how many children are being beaten upon, how many youths are being fired upon... Imagine, if right here, at the heart of New Delhi, justice is being denied, imagine what is being done in police stations of villages and small towns.”

The leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha further said, “We did nothing wrong, we only demanded justice for a son and his mother. Imagine it took eight hours (of dharna), and the final permission had to be given by Amit Shah ji and the home secretary. Then only the FIR was registered. So you understand who was stopping the FIR. The cops wanted to file the FIR but those at the top had put brakes on justice.”

This was the second dharna by Gandhi and his party colleagues after they held one near the prime minister’s residence last month following the police action against student protesters on July 20.

Thanking Gandhi, his lawyer and others, Lochab said, “It is a victory of justice. I felt sad it took such a long time to file the FIR.”

Earlier, Lochab said he had approached the police station on August 14 with a medical report but couldn’t get an FIR filed. Subsequently he posted on August 17 a complaint to the station, but could not obtain details of the investigating officer.

On Friday, the dharna started around noon after Gandhi and Lochab, along with the latter’s mother and lawyer, visited the police station again to press for an FIR. Gandhi then displayed some pellets and blamed the home minister for the delay in filing the FIR. “Amit Shah ji, why are you so scared of justice? This fear shows that you are admitting to your crimes,” he said.



FAILED TO FILE FIR ON AUG 14, SAD IT TOOK SUCH A LONG TIME: SAHIL LOCHAB

19-year-old victim Sahil Lochab said he had approached the police station on August 14 with a medical report, but couldn’t get an FIR filed. Lochab: It is a victory of justice. I felt sad it took such a long time to file FIR

‘AN ATTEMPT TO DIVERT ATTENTION FROM VANDE MATARAM ISSUE’

BJP Hits Out at Rahul Over Dharna Outside Police Station

Our Political Bureau | PTI

New Delhi: BJP on Friday accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of indulging in “cheap and anarchic” politics by staging a dharna outside the Parliament Street police station, alleging that it was an attempt to divert attention from his party’s stand on the Vande Mataram issue.

Union health minister JP Nadra said Gandhi’s dharna was neither for students nor for justice but reflected Congress’ “political frustration” and his “hunger for footage”. “Today, the entire nation has once again witnessed Rahul Gandhi’s cheap and attention-diverting politics, which he displayed outside the Parliament Street police station. Rahul Gandhi’s protest is neither for



Entire nation has once again witnessed Rahul Gandhi’s cheap and attention-diverting politics, which he displayed outside the Parliament Street police station

JP NADRA Union Minister

students nor for justice; it is a symbol of Congress party’s political frustration and Rahul Gandhi’s hunger for footage,” Nadra told reporters here.

“To hide Congress’ anti-national face and divert attention from embarrassment, Rahul Gandhi hastily staged this drama,” he said.

ANARCHIC POLITICS: PRASAD

Senior BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad also accused Gandhi of indulging in “anarchic politics”. Addressing a press conference here, Prasad claimed that Gandhi’s protest was an attempt to divert attention after Congress realised that its stand on the Vande Mataram issue was wrong. “Congress is trapped over its stand on Vande Mataram and is trying to divert attention,” he told reporters. Prasad said Gandhi staged the dharna without permission or prior information and questioned Congress’ decision to protest when an investigation into the matter was already underway.

If right here, at the heart of New Delhi, justice is being denied, imagine what is being done in police stations of villages and small towns... We did nothing wrong, we only demanded justice for a son and his mother... The cops wanted to file the FIR but those at the top had put brakes on justice

RAHUL GANDHI Lok Sabha’s Leader of Opposition

Congress functionaries, including Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Kumari Selja, Randeep Surjewala, Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, Jairam Ramesh and Salman Khurshid, joined the dharna while many Congress workers and members of the party’s youth and student wings gathered outside the police station and raised slogans.

THREE-MEMBER PROBE PANEL FORMED TO LOOK INTO ISSUE

Jadavpur’s Tagore-linked Emblem Damaged in Vandalism; Case Filed

University’s Left-backed professors protest; West Bengal BJP leaders speak in different tones

Our Political Bureau

Kolkata: The vice chancellor of Jadavpur University on Friday lodged police complaints over the violence that broke out on its campus here on August 19 midnight. A three-member probe panel has been formed to look into the issue.

On Thursday afternoon, an iron frame around the varsity’s emblem, designed by legendary artist Nandalal Bose under the instructions of Rabindranath Tagore, was completely broken after protesters allegedly trampled on it while scaling the locked gate on Thursday evening.

Police said a case has been registered following the Jadavpur University VC’s complaint. “In the complaint, he (VC) has stated that on 20.08.2026, after 12.37 am, a group of unknown persons/outsi-

ders allegedly forcibly entered the Jadavpur University campus and indulged in arson, vandalism and intimidation. Burning materials were allegedly thrown into Aurobindo Bhavan, where students and security personnel had taken shelter, thereby endangering their lives,” police said.

VC’S COMPLAINT

A group of unknown persons/outside allegedly forcibly entered the Jadavpur University campus and indulged in arson, vandalism and intimidation: VC in his police complaint

“University property, including CCTV cameras, gates and installations, was damaged, and an attempt was allegedly made to forcibly open

the main hostel gate. Further vandalism was reported at about 14:00 hours on August 20, including damage to the University emblem and adjoining installations,” the police said.

Congress, ABVP and Left-backed unions in the college called for protests on Friday against the vandalism, especially concerning the damage to the university’s historic and iconic emblem. The university’s Left-backed professors protested over the emblem issue.

Members of ABVP and Left unions clashed in front of the Jadavpur University on Thursday, following Wednesday night’s alleged violence inside the campus and altercation between two groups during a student union general body meeting.

Meanwhile, the ruling BJP in West Bengal spoke in different tones on the violence. State finance minister Swapna Dasgupta condemned the desecration of the varsity’s emblem, while his Cabinet colleagues warned of more “surgical strikes”. In a video message on X, Dasgupta advised politicians to stay away from students’ politics and to keep in mind the nationalist heritage of JU, which was a centre of excellence and pointed out that “the emblem was insulted”.



Telangana CM’s US Visit Cancelled as MEA Denies Clearance

Nod denied after delegation had reached the UK for the trip’s first leg

Shilpa Ranipeta

Hyderabad: Telangana CM A Revanth Reddy’s planned visit to the United States has been cancelled after the external affairs ministry denied political clearance for the trip, the CM’s office said on Friday.

The Telangana government said it had sought permission for an official delegation



Reddy, who is currently in London as part of the delegation, will now return to Hyderabad

to visit both the UK and the US. While clearance was granted for the UK leg, permission for the US visit was denied after the delegation had already reached the UK. It claimed that the denial of clearance stemmed from a “political angle”.

Reddy, who is currently in London as part of the ‘Telangana Rising’ delegation, will now return to Hyderabad on Sunday instead of proceeding to Boston and New York.

Poliloquy R PRASAD



We can sing the full song by heart, sir. But can you withstand a revolution?

WATER SHARING TREATY SIGNED IN 1996 FOR 30 YEARS

India-B’desh Ganges Talks Continuing at Technical Level: MEA



FARAKKA BARRAGE

India closely following developments in West Asia, especially Dhaka’s eagerness to join Mecca defence agreement

Dipanjnan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India said on Friday that discussions on river-related issues with Bangladesh, including those concerning the Ganges Water Sharing Treaty, were continuing at the technical level.

Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal made the remarks during the weekly media briefing while responding to a question on the renewal of the Ganges Water Treaty.

“As you would be aware, the Ganges Water Treaty was signed in 1996 for 30 years,” he said, adding, “All river-related issues between India and Bangladesh are discussed under the Joint Rivers Commission. Further, meetings of the committee under the Ganges Water Treaty continue to be held at the technical level,” Jaiswal added.

The 1996 Ganges Water Sharing Treaty between India and Bangladesh is set to expire in December this year. It governs the sharing of the river’s water flow during the lean dry season (January 1 to May 31) at the Farakka Barrage in West Bengal.

Jaiswal said it was closely following developments in West Asia when asked about reports that Bangladesh is keen to join the recently signed Mecca defence pact involving Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye.

MEA’s response comes after Bangladesh foreign affairs adviser Humayun Kabir said in an interview that Dhaka was open to joining the Mecca pact. The Mecca defence agreement was signed on August 7 by Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif.

STRAIGHT TALK

MEA Dismisses Pak ‘Frustration’ Over US Envoy’s J&K Remarks

NEW DELHI: Ministry of External Affairs on

Friday said it sees no reason to comment on Pakistan’s “frustration” after Islamabad summoned a top US diplomat following US ambassador Randhir Jaiswal said, “I will repeat, Jammu, Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and indivisible parts of India. They were, they are and they will remain so.” “I see no reason to comment on Pakistan’s frustration. This is what I have to say,” he said in response to a question on Pakistan sparking a diplomatic protest over Gor’s remarks. Islamabad on Wednesday summoned the US Charge d’Affaires and lodged a protest stating that his remarks regarding the status of Jammu and Kashmir were “factually incorrect” and contradict Washington’s longstanding position on Kashmir. – ANI

LADAKH PROMISES TO BE A NATIONAL SHOWCASE FOR ENVIRONMENTAL PROGRESS: THAROOR

Ladakh Taps Indus Water for Agriculture

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Congress Lok Sabha MP Shashi Tharoor on Friday praised the Ladakh administration for improving water efficiency and agricultural sustainability by diverting millions of litres of untapped glacier runoff daily to parched villages in the mountainous region.

Ladakh LG Vinai Kumar Saxena said his administration had reduced untapped water discharge into the Indus river from nearly 90 million litres a day to around 5 million litres.

“Well done, LG Ladakh. As I discovered during my committee’s recent visit, Ladakh promises to be a national showcase for environmental progress and sustainability. Let’s keep it at it,” Tharoor wrote on X. He led a 10-member parliamentary standing committee on external affairs that visited Ladakh in June.

Saxena said that following his visit to Chuchot village on August 16 and an appeal by residents, the administration had diverted nearly 20 million litres of Stok Glacier water to the dry village canal in Chuchot. He described the move as another step towards addressing the water crisis and ensuring agricultural sustainability.

“Combined with the water already channelised into the Igoo-Phey

NOTED FOR ITS RESEMBLANCE TO POTALA PALACE IN TIBET Gor Visits Thiksey Monastery in Ladakh

LEH: US ambassador to India Sergio Gor visited Thiksey Monastery on Friday. Situated atop a hill in Thiksey, located in the Ladakh region of northern India, the site stands as the largest monastery in central Ladakh and is widely noted for its resemblance to the Potala Palace in Tibet. Located 19 km from Leh, the monastery was founded in 1433 and houses exquisite age-old images, stupas, scroll paintings and wall paintings, as well as a 15-metre-high (48 ft) statue of Maitreya Buddha installed in the 1980s. Celebrated for its daily morning prayers, where visitors gather to experience the spiritual atmosphere, it also offers panoramic views of surrounding hill villages with the Indus river in the background. – ANI

Irrigation Canal, we have succeeded in reducing the untapped water discharge into the Indus river from nearly 90 million litres of water per day to just around 5 million litres daily,” said Saxena.

He said the administration’s objective was to ensure that not a single drop of glacier melt went to waste when farmers needed it for their fields. “Using simple, low-cost

and gravity-based interventions, our engineers have completed this vital task swiftly. This will significantly boost agriculture, livelihoods and water security in Ladakh. We remain committed to identifying such opportunities across the region to harness our natural resources for the prosperity of our local communities,” said Saxena.

Earlier, Saxena said the admini-



Combined with the water already channelised into the Igoo-Phey Irrigation Canal, we have succeeded in reducing the untapped water discharge into the Indus river from nearly 90 million litres of water per day to just around 5 million litres daily

VINAI KUMAR SAXENA Ladakh LG

stration had created two diversions from Stok Nallah to divert 90 million litres of untapped glacier runoff daily from the Stok Kangri glacier into the Igoo-Phey Irrigation Canal. “Out of the 36 cusecs of discharge from the Stok Nallah, 25 cusecs of water has been diverted into the canal, thereby, augmenting water supply into the canal, from 50 cusecs to nearly 75 cusecs,” said Saxena.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

People Want SAD, BJP to Come Together for Peace and Devp of Punjab: Majithia

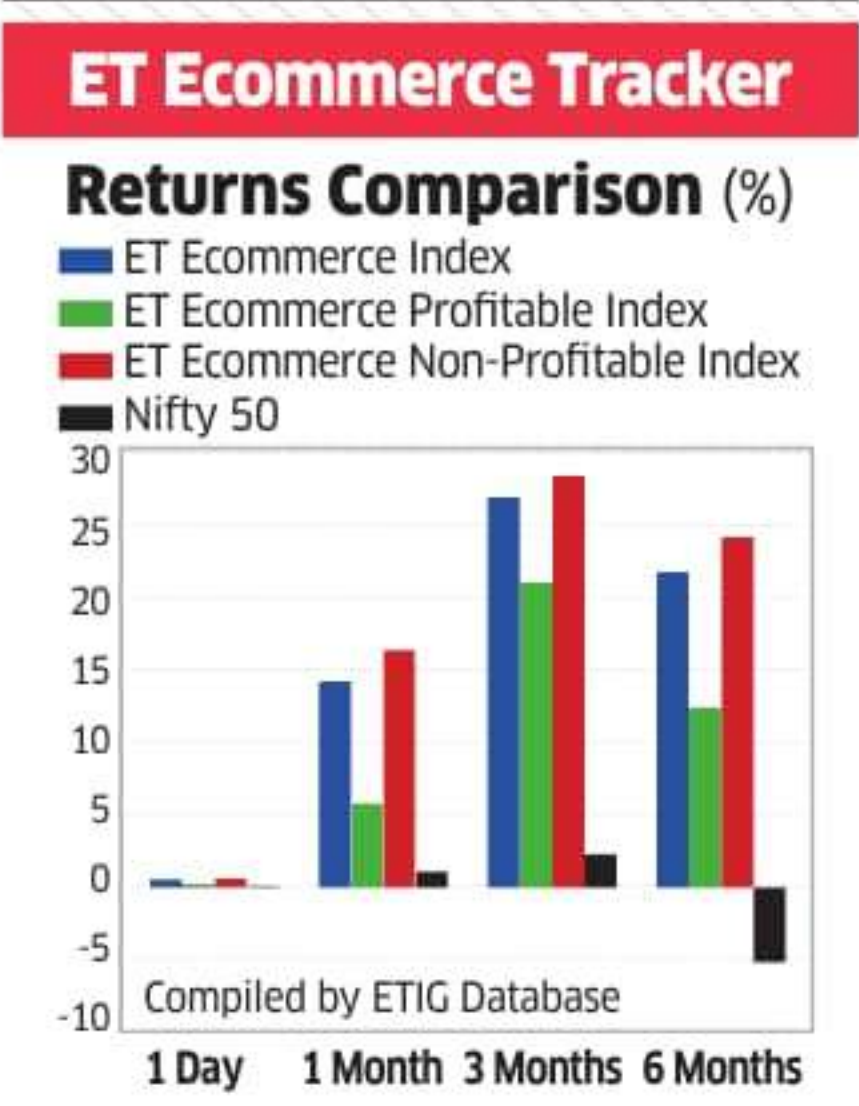
CHANDIGARH: Senior Akali leader Bikram Singh Majithia on Friday said that people want SAD and BJP to come together for peace, development and progress of Punjab. He, however, said any decision in this regard will be taken by the leadership of both the parties. Majithia’s statement came a day after his sister and former Union minister Harsimrat Kaur Badal stoked fresh speculations about a re-alliance between Akali Dal and BJP by expressing a cryptic wish for “agreements” that carried progress to Punjab from Delhi. Referring to the earlier alliance, Majithia said former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee and former Punjab CM Parkash Singh Badal had an alliance based on communal harmony and the Hindu-Sikh unity. – PTI

26/11 Attacks: Cops Seek MHA Help to Serve Order Against Saeed, 5 Others

MUMBAI: Mumbai Police have approached the Union home ministry to serve the court proclamation orders via Interpol against six absconding accused, including LeT founders Hafiz Saeed and Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi, setting the stage to try them in absentia for their role in the 26/11 terror attacks. The police, represented by special public prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam, submitted on Friday an interim report on the proclamation order issued in July against the absconding accused for initiating the process for trial in absentia. “We have written to the Ministry of Home Affairs for taking necessary steps in serving the proclamation order, through Interpol, against the accused residing in Pakistan,” Nikam told the court hearing terror cases. – PTI

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ET tech



Tweet OF THE DAY

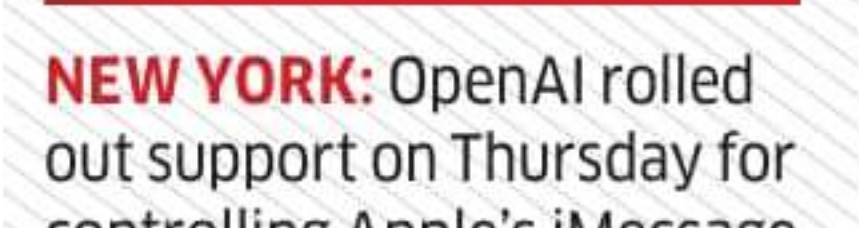


NAVAL @NAVAL

The time to be most ambitious is when you have nothing to lose or nothing left to gain.

Tech Buzz

ChatGPT Can Now Control iMessage



NEW YORK: OpenAI rolled out support on Thursday for controlling Apple's iMessage service via ChatGPT, a move with the potential to raise privacy concerns for the iPhone maker. The new feature, available for ChatGPT on the Mac, allows the OpenAI system to take actions such as reading, writing and sending text messages. It also can search through messages and get summaries and other information about conversations from the Apple Messages app. Apple has positioned itself as a staunch privacy advocate, and it's protective about the contents of users' messages. An OpenAI tool that could upload Apple customer data to that company's network is likely to spark questions. Apple sued OpenAI last month, accusing the AI provider of stealing information about upcoming products. - Bloomberg

1.2million Number of people whose annual drinking-water needs could be exceeded by GPT-4o's inference water use. - Stanford AI Index Report

India Tops APAC Data Centre Mkt Outside China



NEW DELHI: India has emerged as top data centre market in the Asia-Pacific region (APAC), outside China, after its live IT capacity quadrupled over the past six years to 1.7 GW, a report showed on Friday. The country has a strong pipeline with 1.3GW under construction and another 3.2GW of projects that have secured the land, power and permits needed for construction, according to the report by Bloomberg New Energy Finance (NEF). "Strong scores on energy availability and fibre connectivity make India a preferred destination for building data centres in Asia-Pacific," the report noted. Maharashtra remains India's dominant data centre market. It has the largest live IT base, accounting for 55% of the total capacity in the country. - Agencies

Goodbye Metros, Hello Coorg: Elite Nuptials Moving Beyond Big Cities

Infra boom and a demand for exclusive hotel buyouts shift \$229b mkt away from congested metros

Sneha Joseph & Alenjith K Johny

Bengaluru: When San Francisco-based architects Smera Rose Jose and Ashwin Nambiar decided to tie the knot in India, they settled for the quiet and natural settings of Coorg in Karnataka over more popular and convenient destinations.

The couple, who got married in January, didn't want an elaborate décor; a long list of guests, or other paraphernalia associated with many Indian weddings. The event felt like an intimate weekend gathering of people who mattered the most, Jose told ET.

They are among a burgeoning base of Indian couples looking beyond the traditional destination wedding hubs. The search for scenic places and personalised experiences for intimate celebrations is prompting them to venture into smaller towns and offbeat locations.

Wedding planners and décor companies said they are seeing a 20-30% increase in bookings for locations beyond the large cities. Destination weddings in Tier 2 and 3 cities rose 12% in the past year, according to the Event and Entertainment Management Association.

"People don't want to go to Goa, Delhi, or Mumbai anymore," said Shehzarin Udawadia, cofounder at Double S Enterprises, a Mumbai-based wedding planning and event design firm. High-income families able to afford homes in metros such as Mumbai or Hyderabad are scouting for quieter destinations that can accommodate 300-400 guests, she said.

"We wanted it to feel personal," said Jose, explaining the reason behind selecting the misty hill station of Coorg. "For us, that meant having the people we are close to there, rather than letting the guest list keep growing just because that's what happens traditionally."

GOING BEYOND THE USUAL

For many couples looking for off-beat places to exchange vows, the attraction is simple: they offer more privacy and flexibility, allowing them to savour every moment of one of the most important days of their lives. They also come without the premium price tag of a big city or a popular destination. "People had warned us that your wedding can go by in a blur," said Jose. "But because ours was intimate, we had time to talk to people, take it all in, and simply enjoy it. We remember the little things—the conversations, food, music and dancing."

The appeal is also about creating an experience that feels different.

For affluent families, destination weddings are increasingly becoming a way to avoid repeating the same format, said Parthip Thyagarajan, chief executive at wedding planning platform WeddingSutra.

A family that hosted its last wedding in Jaipur, for instance, may choose Udaipur, Bengaluru, or Kochi the next time.

Spending by wealthy individuals on weddings climbed 20-25% year-on-year between November 2025 and March 2026, with smaller towns driving much of the increase, according to WeddingSutra, a data aggregator on the luxury wedding business.

Coorg, Jaisalmer, Mahabalipuram, Surat, Rajkot, Nagpur and Kochi are among locations gaining popularity as wedding destinations. The Himalayan state of Uttarakhand is also attracting couples looking for an alternative to beach or traditional South Indian weddings. For those exploring the opposite, Kerala offers an array of great settings.

"Kerala has everything from Kovalam's beaches and the hills of Wayanad and Munnar to Athirappally's waterfalls and the backwaters," said Midhun Madhusoodhan, chief operating officer at Mindful Memories Photography & Films.

"Couples from across India are now looking at the state for wedding events."

India's wedding services market is projected to nearly double to about \$229 billion by 2030 from \$117 billion in 2025. The destination wedding market alone is expected to grow more than threefold to \$55.39 billion by 2033 from \$16.25 billion in 2024, according to Grand View Research.

HOSPITALITY EXPANDS HORIZON

Expansion of the hospitality sector is also fuelling the growing popularity of small cities, towns, and the hinterlands as wedding destinations. In fact, both complement each other, say people tracking the sectors.

Priti Sidhwani, founder at DreamzKrraft, which organised celebrity weddings including actor Preity Zinta, said opening of hotels in small cities and towns has made such places more viable.

"Earlier, nothing used to be available in these places," said Sidhwani. "Over time, hotels built up inventory, which makes things more economical for clients."



Spreading Joy



Deal Corner

Deals keep rolling in as investors hunt for new winners

Atomberg Tech Files Draft IPO Papers for ₹450cr Fresh Issue

Existing investors to offload up to 76.5 million shares; OFS value to hinge on final price band

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Consumer appliances company Atomberg Technologies has filed its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) for an initial public offering (IPO) comprising a fresh issue of up to ₹450 crore and an offer for sale of up to 76.5 million shares by existing non-promoter investors.

The offer-for-sale (OFS) value will depend on the price band the company opts for. Mumbai-based A91 Partners will sell up to 37.7 million shares, while Singapore's Temasek will be offloading 12.2 million shares, the filing showed. Singapore-based Jungle Ventures will also sell 9.95 million shares, along with Inflexor Ventures, Steadview Capital and Survam Partners.

The promoters are not selling any shares under the IPO.

The offer for sale comes after several secondary transactions in which Atomberg's early shareholders sold equity and preference shares worth nearly ₹683 crore since 2019, according to ET's calculations from the prospectus. A91, the largest seller in the IPO, accounted for about ₹445 crore of these sales through transactions with Steadview and entities linked to Temasek and Jungle Ventures, among others. Promoters Manoj Meena and Sibabrata Das, who are not selling shares in the IPO, separately realised about ₹72 crore through earlier transactions. Atomberg did not receive proceeds from these sales. The DRHP said Atomberg may seek external funding for its business-to-business engineering arm, Atomberg Innovation, which develops motors, controllers and other components for appliance makers.



ET first reported on July 31 that Atomberg was preparing a ₹1,500-2,000 crore IPO within weeks and that its B2B engineering arm was raising ₹150-200 crore in a round led by General Catalyst, with Mirae Asset Management considering participation. While General Catalyst has backed out, the company is currently in discussions with existing investor Jungle Ventures as well as Mirae Asset, people aware of the matter said.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Ultraviolette Eyeing \$45-50 million More in Ongoing Round

Taps existing backers like Speciale Invest, TDK, others; value may top last round's \$340m mark

Ayanti Bera & Disha Acharya

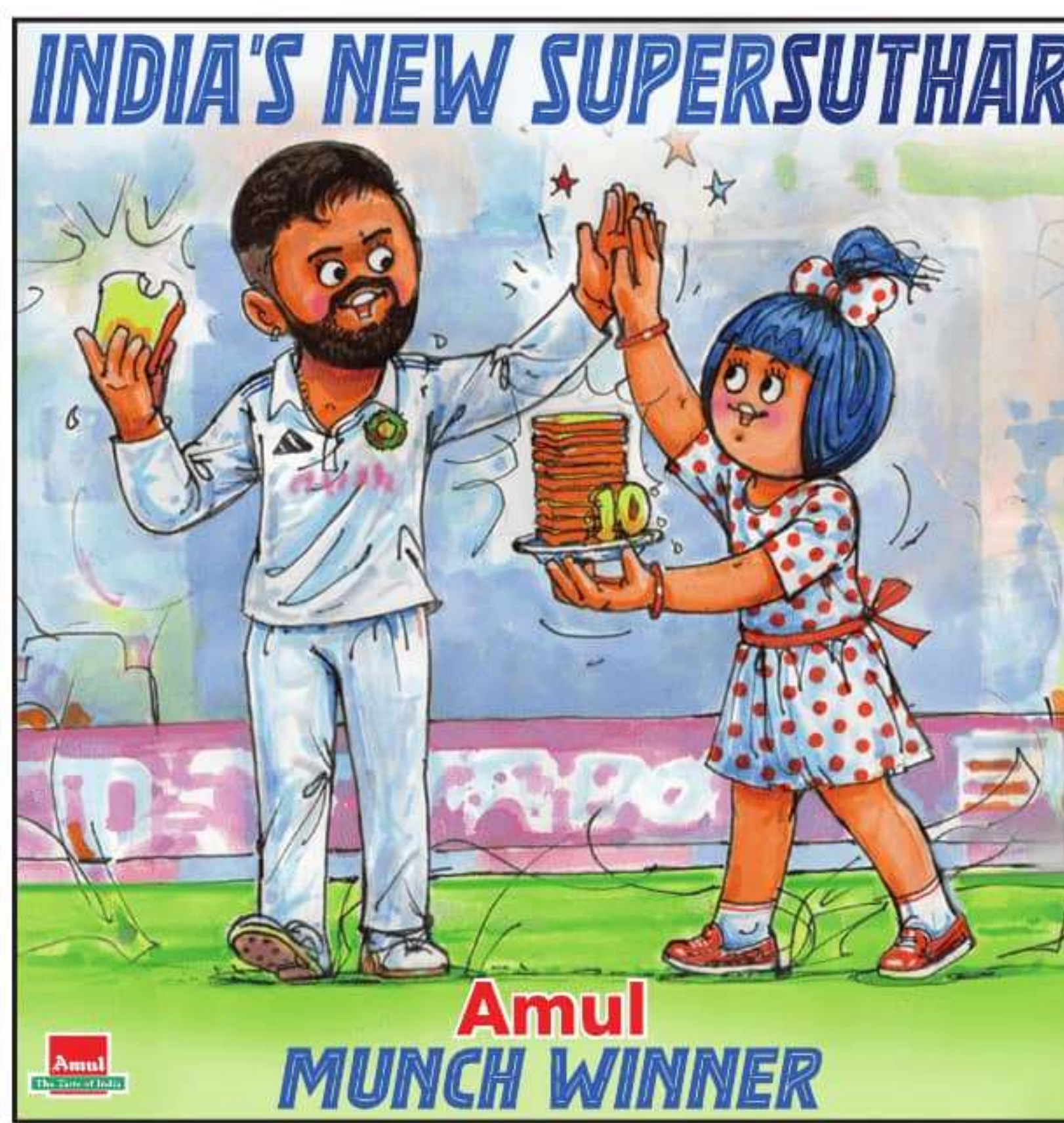
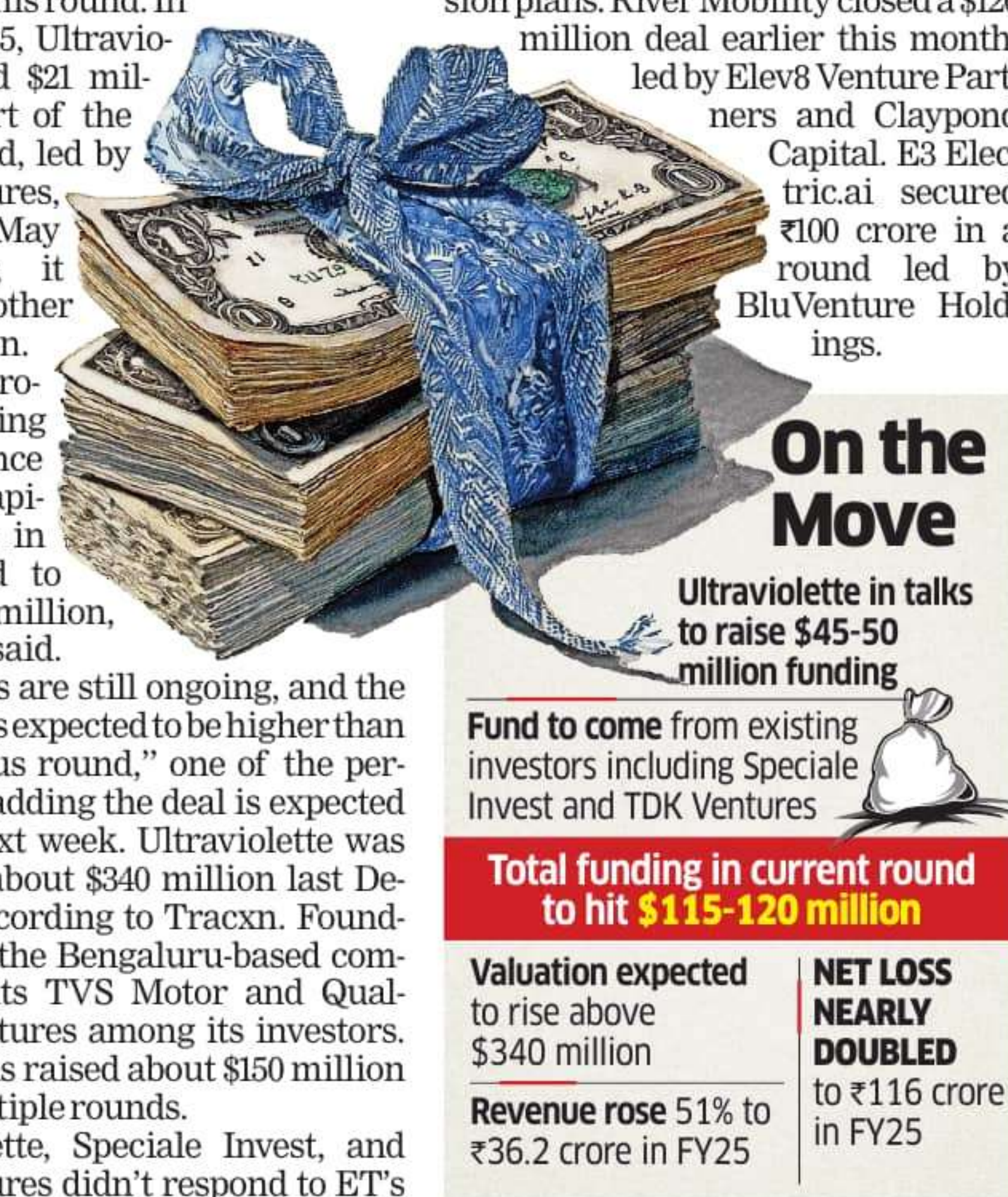
Bengaluru: Electric motorcycle maker Ultraviolette is in talks to raise an additional \$45-50 million from existing investors, including Speciale Invest and TDK Ventures, as part of its ongoing fundraising round, people aware of the developments told ET.

The company garnered \$45 million from Zoho Corporation and Italian investment firm Lingotto last December as part of this round. In August 2025, Ultraviolette raised \$21 million as part of the same round, led by TDK Ventures, and in May that year it raised another \$3.85 million.

The proposed funding will enhance the total capital raising in this round to \$115-120 million, the people said.

"The talks are still ongoing, and the valuation is expected to be higher than the previous round," one of the persons said, adding the deal is expected to close next week. Ultraviolette was valued at about \$340 million last December, according to Tracxn. Founded in 2016, the Bengaluru-based company counts TVS Motor and Qualcomm Ventures among its investors. So far, it has raised about \$150 million across multiple rounds.

Ultraviolette, Speciale Invest, and TDK Ventures didn't respond to ET's queries. Ultraviolette has a retail presence in 35 cities across the country. Its overseas footprint expanded to a dozen countries after it started selling the F77 model in the UK last year.



Paytm Expanding AI, High-margin Fintech Bets, says Sharma

Firm to use AI to build its next-gen biz, but payments will remain its core: CEO

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Paytm founder and chief executive Vijay Shekhar Sharma said the fintech company will accelerate investments across AI, financial services, and its merchant ecosystem after recording its first profitable full financial year, overcoming a turbulent two-year period overshadowed by regulatory disruption and a sharp focus on cost cuts.

"This has been a defining year for Paytm," Sharma said in his letter to shareholders, highlighting the business is now "sustainably profitable" and has the confidence to "invest profitably more than ever before".

He said Paytm would use technology and AI to build the next generation of businesses, while keeping payments as its foundation.

The comments track a sharp turnaround at One97 Communications, which runs Paytm. The company swung to its first full-year profit in FY26 of ₹552 crore, from ₹663 crore net loss the year before, helped by a 22% rise in operating revenue at ₹8,437 crore. Ebitda swung to ₹502 crore from a loss of ₹1,506 crore a year earlier.

Paytm's growth momentum continued in the June quarter, as it posted record quarterly Ebitda of ₹203 crore, up 182% year-on-year, and profit after tax of ₹220 crore, up 79%.

The recovery follows the crisis triggered in January 2024 when the Reserve Bank of India restricted Paytm Payments Bank from accepting fresh deposits and providing several key services after citing persistent regulatory non-compliance. The action sent Paytm scrambling to move its UPI and payments relationships to other banks, while its shares fell to a record low of ₹38.35 in February 2024.

Paytm subsequently moved its UPI business to the third-party application provider model while rebuilding its consumer and merchant payments operations around partner banks. When the RBI ultimately cancelled the payments bank licence in April this year, Paytm said there was no material impact on business since its products had already migrated to third-party banks.

The turnaround also played out on the stock market. Paytm shares closed at Rs 1,632 on Thursday, more than five times their February 2024 low and close to their 52-week high of ₹1,657.60.

Sharma said most of



"This has been a defining year for Paytm... the business is now 'sustainably profitable' and has the confidence to 'invest profitably more than ever before'"

VIJAY SHEKHAR SHARMA
Founder & CEO, Paytm

Paytm's profits are currently generated by its merchant business. Merchant gross merchandise value rose 26% to about ₹23.8 lakh crore in FY26, while the subscription merchant base increased to 1.51 crore from 1.24 crore a year earlier.

Financial services is becoming another key monetisation engine. Revenue from the segment surged 52% to ₹2,594 crore in FY26, accounting for 31% of revenue, up from 25% a year earlier.

The board recommended raising Sharma's fixed pay to ₹7 crore in FY27, with an annual increment of up to 15%, and a performance-linked variable component capped at 200% of fixed pay, subject to shareholder approval. Sharma drew total remuneration of ₹4.33 crore in FY26. The proposed revision followed an independent benchmarking exercise that found his existing remuneration materially below the median across three comparator groups.

Paytm is also pushing AI deeper into its operations, using models built on leading open-source systems and smaller language models trained for small businesses, voice and Indian languages. It is deploying AI for fraud detection, merchant onboarding and collections, while agentic tools are being used to increase engineering output without a proportionate increase in headcount.

Cognizant Alerts Clients of Data Breach, Offers \$1m ID Theft Cover

Says data breach occurred around April 21, but no proof of any misuse

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The personal information of several customers of IT services company Cognizant may have been exposed in a data breach around April 21 this year, according to media reports.

The Teaneck-headquartered company said in a notification to customers that it has "no reason to believe" the information was misused, but has decided to notify affected individuals. It is offering them identity theft protection and up to \$1 million in insurance coverage for eligible losses. ET has seen a copy of the notification.

The incident was reported to the Massachusetts Office of Consumer Affairs and Business Regulation. A spokesperson for Cognizant said



on Friday the incident relates to a "previously disclosed incident from earlier this year" and is not a new development. "Cognizant takes the protection of our clients' information very seriously," the spokesperson said. The company's notification did not disclose the number of individuals affected or provide details on how the breach occurred.

Cognizant said affected customers can place a security freeze on their credit reports free of charge. It has also engaged IDX, a data breach and recovery services provider, to offer 24 months of credit and CyberScan monitoring, fully managed identity-theft recovery services and a \$1-million insurance reimbursement policy.

The data breach at Cognizant follows cyber incidents at some other Indian IT services companies. Earlier this month, HCLTech and Tata Consultancy Services had separately informed the stock exchanges about attempts by unidentified hacker groups to obtain employee data. Hackers claimed access to information related to more than 250,000 employees of HCLTech. ET had reported earlier in the week that such incidents have prompted IT services companies to increase spending on cybersecurity and business continuity.

Memory Stocks Face Headwinds as 'Smart Money' Walks Out

Stocks remain among S&P 500's top performers, but now they're stuck

Bloomberg

Washington: After ripping through the first half of the year, memory stocks are struggling to regain momentum as growing concerns about the state of the artificial intelligence trade overshadow their strong fundamental backdrop.

While Sandisk Corp, Micron Technology, Western Digital Corp and Seagate Technology Holdings remain among the top performers in the S&P 500 Index this year, the shares are way off their highs. Now they appear to be stuck, trading around where they were in May.

"The smart money is moving on," said Alec Young, chief investment strategist at MoneyFlows, a quant-research firm. Momentum investors are looking

elsewhere in the market for returns, he added, as evidenced by Moderna Inc.'s historic 177% rally on Wednesday and the rebound in speculative assets like Bitcoin, which is on pace for its best week since November 2024. Shares of Sandisk and Western Digital fell Friday morning, while Micron and Seagate rose slightly.



This is a substantial change, since momentum investors have been feasting on the memory and storage stocks for a while. Massive demand for AI infrastructure dramatically raised prices of memory chips and other components, creating enormous revenue growth that sent the stocks flying. Micron and Seagate more than tripled last year, while Western Digital nearly did as well. Sandisk, which began trading in February 2025, ended the year up more than 500% and then leaped another 143% in January.

Midway through 2026, every member of the group had more than tripled for the year, led by Sandisk's 858% surge from the start of January through June 30. It was the most "over-owned" large-cap tech stock relative to its weight in the S&P 500 in the second quarter, according to Morgan Stanley.

Alamgir Takes Oath as Bangladesh President

Dhaka: Veteran politician Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir was on Friday sworn in as Bangladesh's 23rd President. Alamgir was administered the oath by Jatiya Sangsad (Parliament) Acting Speaker Kayser Kamal at the Darbar Hall of Bangabhaban. Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, Opposition Leader Shafiqur Rahman, former Chief Adviser Muhammad Yunus, Cabinet ministers, top army brass and several other officials were present at the oath ceremony. PTI

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Tender No.NMMT/TM/ESTATE/04/2026-27

Description:- Lease of Office Spaces on 7th & 8th Floor (area 21820 sq.ft) at “Bus Terminus Complex of Sector 12 Vashi” through auction..

Which is available on Website <https://mahatenders.gov.in> Right to accept or reject any tender is reserved by the Hon'ble Transport Manager of NMMT.

Sd/-
(Umakant Jangle)
Transport Manager,
N.M.M.T.

NMMT/TM/ADMIN/510/2026, Dt. 21.08.2026

**SBI**

Analytics Department, 8th Floor,
NEWA Bhakti Knowledge Park, Airoli, Navi Mumbai - 400708

CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

RefNo: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 Dated: 21.08.2026

Corrigendum with reference to RFP No: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 dated 25.07.2026 has been published on Bank's website. For details, please visit 'Procurement News' at <https://www.sbi.bank.in>

Place: Mumbai **Deputy General Manager**

Date: 22.08.2026 **Analytics Department (DB - Business)**

SOUTHERN RAILWAY

MATERIALS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
AUCTION PROGRAMME - SEPTEMBER- 2026
NOTICE No : 09 / 2026

e-Auction will be conducted for disposal of Ferrous scrap, Non-Ferrous scrap, other Misc scrap, condemned Wagon, Coaches & Locos, Scrap Rails and other Permanent Way scrap material.

SI No	e-Auction conducted by	Date of auction for the month of for September 2026			Material for auction
1	GSD/PER	02/09/26	15/09/26	28/09/26	
2	CSSD/GOC	03/09/26	16/09/26	24/09/26	
3	SSD/PTJ	04/09/26	11/09/26	21/09/26	
4	MAS	09/09/26	16/09/26	23/09/26	
5	SA	04/09/26	11/09/26	21/09/26	
6	TVC	08/09/26	18/09/26	29/09/26	
7	PGT	03/09/26	10/09/26	22/09/26	
8	TPJ	07/09/26	17/09/26	25/09/26	
9	MDU	07/09/26	17/09/26	25/09/26	

Total no. of auctions - 27

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Principal Chief Materials Manager

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real estate

FARM HOUSES

3.10 Acres Farmhouse Property Hosur-Sarjapur Border 2,500 sq.ft farmhouse with veranda & terrace, wellgrown teakwood,fruit trees, landscaped park area. Excellent potential for plotted development with clubhouse and amenities. Contact 9880076543 for details and site visit

LAND FOR SALE

KORAMANGALA 2400 Sq.ft. 40 X 60 with old house. Contact: 6369080677

BANGALORE PROPERTIES

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WANTED BANASHANKARI 6th STAGE, ANY BLOCK, 30x40 ANY FACE, DIRECT REGISTRATION. CALL : MANOJ - 9731410616

BIDADI

RENT : 28000sqft WAREHOUSE, 38 ft height, opp. Toyota Main Gate Bidadi. Available from 01/04/2027. Call: 9844090676 & 9844060555

BOMMASANDRA

43590 SFT Industrial Land in Jigani Industrial Area(KIARD) - Built to Suit OR Lease Out.Contact: 9663436944

KORAMANGALA

740 sq sqft Furnished office @ Raheja Arcade, Koramangala (opp. Nexus) for sale. Prime Location. No brokers. Only Genuine buyers : 70105 13455.

KORAMANGALA 1ST BLOCK Prime Location 50x80, 4,000 Sq.Ft. Old House North Facing Immediate Settlement Call: 98450 22510

MG ROAD & AROUND

SALE: Off MG Road Commercial Office Space 20,000 Sft. Stand Alone Building with OC. Ideal for Corporate Offices. Contact: "IRSHADS" - 98450-31500.

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5454 sft North east corner shed on 60ft road with 40HP power on Andrahalli main rd, Peenya 2nd stage, KSSDC 1st allottee. BROKERS STRICTLY EXCUSE. Rs. 9 crores. Direct Owner: 9686111709

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BANGALORE

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2 BHK Flat For Sale in RAIYAN SPLENDOR Society HBR Layout Block 1, Bangalore Area:1050+180 Sqft (1.23 Cr) Mob:9811147596

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Land. Contact:
Taurus Realty
Arun Ph: 9019922999

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personal

CHANGE OF NAME

I, SWASTI HEBBAR, daughter of K Muralidhara Hebbar, residing at Flat No.C-502, 5th Floor, KHB Platinum Apartment, Kengeri Satellite Town, Bengaluru South, Bengaluru - 560060, have changed my name from SWASTI MURALIDHARA HEBBAR to SWASTI HEBBAR vide Affidavit No. IN-KA6599836601495Y dated 20-Aug-2026 sworn before the Notary Surekha V at Bengaluru.

THE TIMES OF INDIA

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PLEA ON MINIMUM WAGES, DELAYED PAY FOR RURAL JOB SCHEME WORKERS

SC: Should Right to Work Be a Fundamental Right?

Our Political Bureau

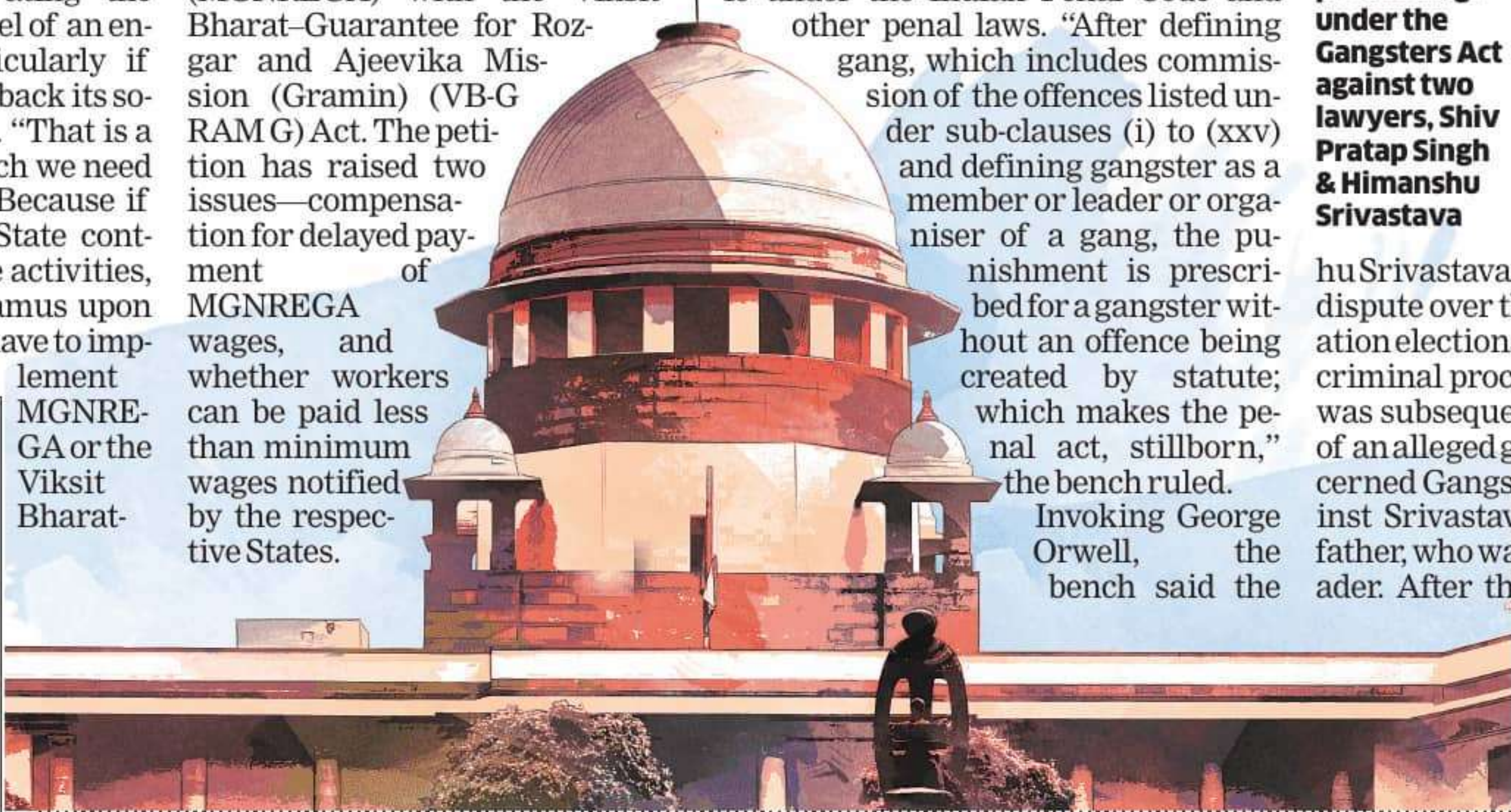
New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday questioned whether the statutory guarantee of employment for rural workers can be placed on the same footing as the fun-

CORRIGENDUM

Please note that in the advertisement dated 21 August 2026 issued by Pilikula Golf Club, the name **Pilikula Development Authority** appearing in the advertisement may kindly be read as **PILIKULA GOLF CLUB** (Part of Pilikula Development Authority).

damental right to life and dignity. A three-member bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymaya Bagchi and V Mohana noted that the Constitution doesn't recognise the right to work as a fundamental right but places it among the state's obligations under the Directive Principles of State Policy. **"Should we create it on a par with Article 21?" said Justice Bagchi.** He then flagged the broader constitutional implications of elevating the right to work to the level of an enforceable right, particularly if the State were to scale back its social welfare measures. "That is a very big question which we need to answer," he said. "Because if we do that, and the State contracts its social welfare activities, can we issue a mandamus upon them and say, no, you have to implement MGNREGA or the Viksit Bharat-

-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (BG RAM) scheme?". The SC was hearing a plea concerning payment of minimum wages and compensation for delayed wages for rural employment guarantee workers. Advocate Prashant Bhushan, representing the petitioner, contended that the petition wasn't rendered infructuous by the replacement of Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) with the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act. The petition has raised two issues—compensation for delayed payment of MGNREGA wages, and whether workers can be paid less than minimum wages notified by the respective States.



WILL IDENTIFY AND DRIVE OUT EVERY SINGLE INFILTRATOR: UNION HOME MINISTER

Eight DMs Empowered to Fast-Track CAA Certificates: Shah in West Bengal

'Every Hindu, Sikh, Jain and other refugee brothers who came from Bangladesh will be granted citizenship'

Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: Union home minister Amit Shah said in Siliguri on Friday that the Centre has given powers to eight West Bengal District Magistrates for the quick issuance of CAA certificates to Hindu refugees. "When I brought the CAA law, Mamata Banerjee mocked me and said she will not accept it. Mamata Didi, your government is gone. Now, it is the government of the BJP I promise every Hindu, Sikh, Jain, and other refugee brothers who came from Bangladesh and were subject to religious persecution that we will grant citizenship," Shah said. "All the refugees will get Indian citizenship in an expedited manner," Shah said. "But for infiltrators, we will follow the 'detect, delete, and deport' policy. We will drive out every single infiltrator from West Bengal." Claiming that "rule of law" prevails in Bengal now with the new BJP

government in power, **Shah said the previous government did not implement BNS in Bengal so that they could promote cut money, syndicate raj and corruption.** He praised CM Suvenudh Adhikari who has fulfilled 43% of the poll promises made in the BJP's manifesto 'San'kalp Patra' in just 100 days. Inaugurating an exhibition on the country's three new criminal laws at Kakwahali Ground in Siliguri, Shah said now the BNS, BNSS and BSA are being implemented by the new government. Slamming the previous CM, who never participated in Sashastra Seema Bal programmes, Shah said, "Suvenudji had said that for the first time a Chief Minister of Bengal got the opportunity to come to the SSB programme. I want to make a correction. We used to invite former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee but she does not want to come to the SSB program. We invited you and you have come."



Union home minister Amit Shah shares a traditional 'Bara Khana' with personnel of the Sashastra Seema Bal at the SSB Frontier Headquarters in Siliguri, Bengal, on Friday – IANS

LINKED WITH NATIONAL SECURITY: HOME MIN 'Triangular Security Grid Formed for Siliguri Corridor'

Kolkata: Home minister Amit Shah on Friday said a triangular security grid has been formed for the strategically located Siliguri Corridor and it is linked with national security. Siliguri Corridor, also known as Chicken's Neck, shares borders with Nepal, Bhutan and Bangladesh. Shah, who was speaking in Siliguri at a Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) Frontier Headquarters programme, said the borders must be completely secured and barbed fencing completed to stop infiltration. "PM Narendra Modi government has recognised the national security and importance of the Siliguri Corridor. It is a very sensitive and important corridor connecting eight states-Bengal and seven sisters in NE," Shah said. "We have made a triangular security grid to make the security of the Siliguri Corridor impregnable. Chopra, Kishanganj and Dhubri—from all these three bases, we have increased our presence, dominance and created awareness in the entire Siliguri Corridor. We have taken up exercises like Teesta Prahar and many such exercises." —Jayatri Nag

EASING OWNERSHIP UNCERTAINTY

State Clears Bill to Help B Khata Property Owners

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The state assembly on Friday approved an amendment that could give lakhs of property owners in old unauthorised layouts a legal route to secure A khata records, easing decades of ownership and administrative uncertainty. The Karnataka Municipal Corporations (Amendment) Bill, 2026, provides for eligible plots and houses in unauthorised layouts to be converted from B khata to A khata after roads in such layouts are formally recognised as public roads. Introducing the Bill, Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda said this was part of the government's commitment to provide secure and legally recognised ownership, which he described as a "Land Guarantee". The amendment to Section 284 of the Karnataka Municipal Corporations Act seeks to address problems arising from unauthorised layouts that came up across urban Karnataka over the past 3-4 decades. Many such layouts were developed without adequate roads, drainage, electricity, drinking water and other basic infrastructure, leaving property owners with B khata records and limited access to formal property rights and approvals.

B KHATA TO A KHATA

Under the amendment, roads earmarked in eligible unauthorised layouts can be declared public roads and formally recorded as such by the municipal body. Once the roads are recognised, eligible property owners can apply for A khata, subject to prescribed rules. The move is expected to improve access to bank loans and ease hurdles in obtaining building plan approvals and Occupancy Certificates, subject to statutory requirements. Byre Gowda said the government had in 2024 decided to stop the creation of new unauthorised layouts while finding a solution for properties in legacy layouts. "Ownership can have real security only when property owners are able to obtain A khata," he said. The government said the system, already implemented in Bengaluru, would be extended to civic bodies across Karnataka.

Tender documents along with EMD details may be downloaded from Karnataka public procurement portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Interested tenderers participate in the tender by logging on the website www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in and also may contact KPPP Help line No:080-46010000/080-68948777. any corrections related to the tender will be published on the KPP portal itself.

Tender Schedule: Date of Commencement of Tender: 21-08-2026; Pre Bid Meeting: 25-08-2026 at 11.30AM; Last date for submission of Tender: 28-08-2026 03:00PM; Date of opening Technical Tender: 29-08-2026 03:10PM; Date of opening Commercial Tender: 29-08-2026 03:15PM

For KARNATAKA MILK FEDERATION LTD, Sd/- DIRECTOR (PURCHASE).

In a Nutshell

IndiGo Website Faces Booking Glitches Again

NEW DELHI: India's largest airline IndiGo was experiencing intermittent issues with its core reservation platform on Friday, the second such disruption this week, as users again faced problems booking flights online. IndiGo's website on Friday displayed an advisory identical to one it issued on Wednesday, citing "intermittent issues" with its core reservation platform. It was not immediately clear whether the problems were linked to Wednesday's disruption or whether the earlier issue had been fully resolved, and IndiGo did not respond to an email seeking more details. The airline held a 67% share of India's domestic aviation market in July.

SATS Plans Integrated Multimodal Logistics Hubs

SINGAPORE: Expressing strong optimism about India's economic growth, Singapore-based SATS said it is keen on building integrated multimodal logistics facilities to bolster the country's manufacturing sector. "We are bullish on India," Bob Chi, CEO of SATS' Gateway Services for Asia Pacific, said at a business forum on Thursday after the conclusion of the India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable held this week in the city-state. Gateway Services for Asia Pacific is the ground handling and in-flight catering unit of SATS. The group has businesses in 14 Indian cities and has also committed up to ₹4,500 crore investment at the Noida International Airport as part of its many investments in India's airport logistics hub along with planned multi-modal transshipment centres across major metros.

AERA Slashes User Fee at Bengaluru Int'l Airport

MUMBAI: Regulator AERA on Friday steeply slashed the user development fee at the Bengaluru international airport to ₹300 for domestic and ₹997 for international passengers for the five-year control period till March 2031. For the first time, the watchdog implemented the incremental ARR (average revenue requirement) framework wherein the cost borne by the Bengaluru airport operator can be recovered from the passengers only after completing the high-value capex projects. Previously, the user development fee (UDF) was recovered from the flyers before project completion.

TaMo Passenger Vehicles to Cost up to ₹25k More from Next Month

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles on Friday said it will hike prices of its vehicles across its models by up to ₹25,000 from September 1 to partially offset increase in input costs and inflationary pressures. The price increase across the portfolio, covering both internal combustion engine (ICE) and electric vehicles will vary across models and variants, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles (TMPV) said in a statement.



"This price revision is being undertaken to partially offset the impact of rising input costs and sustained inflationary pressures," the company said. Tata Motors joins a clutch of other carmakers including Maruti Suzuki India, Hyundai Motor India and Mahindra & Mahindra who also announced price hikes citing higher commodity prices. Hyundai said on

Wednesday it will increase prices by one percentage point. Maruti said prices across its model line-up will go up by up to ₹30,000 effective August 1. Mahindra raised prices by an average of 2.7% on its SUVs and 2% on commercial vehicles, effective July 10, 2026. While TMPV continues to absorb a significant portion of these increases, a part of the impact is being passed on to customers through this adjustment, it added. The extent of the price increase will vary across models and variants, ensuring that the overall value proposition of each offering is maintained, the company said.

Samsung Readies Plan to Return \$80b to Investors

Co joins SK Hynix in sharing AI gains with shareholders

Bloomberg

Samsung Electronics plans to return as much as \$110 trillion won (\$80 billion) to investors this year, joining SK Hynix in sharing an AI windfall and putting in motion the largest shareholder return programme in South Korea's history. The world's biggest memory maker will give about half of its free cash flow to shareholders, with \$30 trillion won of cash dividends planned for the third quarter, it said in a regulatory filing on Friday. It also aims to buy back about \$15 trillion won of stock for employee compensation. Samsung didn't elaborate on how it would pay out the remainder of the targeted amount. Samsung's programme ranks among the largest-ever shareholder return plans. In 2024, Apple approved \$110 billion of repurchases in what was dubbed the biggest US stock buy-back ever. Still, Friday's announcement didn't include the proportion allocated

to share buybacks and cancellations. Samsung said the remaining returns will be finalised at a January board meeting. Its shares erased gains and fell 2.6% in post-market trading after some investors found the announcement underwhelming. The won strengthened on Friday, rising as much as 1%. "Some investors have recently expected up to \$150 trillion won of shareholder returns, which explains the post-market share" action, said Kim Minji, a portfolio manager at Must Asset Mana-

gement. The moves by the two suppliers of memory to Nvidia—and key architects of the AI buildout—respond to growing investor pressure to share more of the cash generated by the boom. SK Hynix's \$40 trillion won buyback plan has added pressure on Samsung to return more cash to shareholders, who point to the electronics giant's swelling reserves. Expectations of a sizable shareholder return program have buoyed Samsung's stock this week. "This could help spark a broader structural change across the Korean stock market," said Tom Kang, research director at Counterpoint. "We see this as a solid step toward a more shareholder-focused style of management—much closer to what you typically see in the US market." Samsung's preferred shares surged more than 8% ahead of the announcement on Friday. The surge may reflect expectations for stronger shareholder returns and higher dividends for preferred shares.

Colgate-Palmolive Names Old Hand Anandani as India Chief

Anandani to take charge from next month; Prabha Narasimhan promoted to global role

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Colgate-Palmolive India has appointed former company executive Manish Anandani as managing director and chief executive officer, returning him to the oral-care maker after an eight-year stint away. Anandani, who currently heads Kenvue's (formerly Johnson and Johnson Consumer Health) India and South Asia business, will take over on September 28 from Prabha Narasimhan, who has been elevated to the role of executive vice-president, marketing, Asia-Pacific.

The transition comes after four years of Narasimhan leading the India business, during which Colgate sharpened its focus on premiumisation, digital channels and category development. The company said premium portfolio growth accelerated to five times the pace of the broader market un-

der her tenure. Under Narasimhan, Colgate India's net sales increased from ₹5,680.4 crore in FY24, her first full financial year, to ₹6,035 crore in FY26, growing at a compound annual growth rate of 3.1%. Net profit rose from ₹1,323.7 crore to ₹1,325.3 crore, at a

CAGR of 0.1% over the same period. PBDIT fell from around ₹1,957.8 crore in FY24 to ₹1,933.8 crore in FY26, a CAGR of -0.6%. Anandani has previously spent 13 years within Colgate-Palmolive across roles in India, IndoChina and the corporate office before becoming worldwide director across

PRIOR EXPERIENCE

Manish Anandani has previously spent about 13 years within Colgate-Palmolive across roles in India, IndoChina and the corporate office

₹1,603 crore over the same period. The company stock has fallen 9.7% year-to-date against BSE FMCG index which fell 9% during period. On Friday, shares of Colgate-Palmolive closed at ₹1,889.9 a piece, down 0.58% from its previous close.

offices. He brings 30 years of experience across sales, marketing, general management and senior leadership, the company said. For the first quarter of FY27, Colgate-Palmolive India reported a profit of ₹343 crore, up 8% year-on-year, while revenue rose 12% to



PAYS ₹ ₹414 CRORE State Bank of India Acquires Office Property in Pune

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: State Bank of India (SBI) has acquired a commercial property, including a prime land parcel and a building, in Pune's Kharadi area for ₹414 crore, in one of the largest office asset transactions concluded by a bank. The deal involves assignment of leasehold rights over 2.12 acres of land at Kharadi Knowledge Park, along with outright ownership of around 1.84 lakh sq ft commercial building constructed on the plot. The building comprises a basement, stilt and 15 floors and has 200 car parking spaces. SBI, the country's largest lender, acquired the property from Siddhivinayak Enterprises through a deed of assignment, according to registration documents accessed through CRE Matrix, a real estate data analytics platform. The transaction attracted stamp duty of ₹29 crore. The acquisition gives SBI ownership of the building while the underlying land is held on a leasehold basis.

AIMING TO BECOME A 'COMPLETE LUXURY HOUSE'

Sabyasachi to Enter New Segments to Broaden Footprint

The luxury brand is planning fragrances, footwear and leather goods, says founder

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Sabyasachi Mukherjee, founder and creative director of the eponymous label, said the luxury lifestyle brand is planning to enter new categories such as fragrances and footwear besides small leather goods and expanding eyewear into a much larger segment.

"The ambition has always been to build India's first global luxury lifestyle brand. I think the business is beginning to demonstrate the breadth required to do that," he added. The brand clocked revenues of ₹650 crore in financial year 2026. "Our first fragrance should arrive in the next 18 months and small leather goods such as wallets will help us tap into a much broader ecosystem. The Middle East is a growing market for us. We will continue to grow eastwards and westwards," said Mukherjee. Mukherjee said what is particularly encouraging is the evolution of the business.

"Jewellery is now close to 33% of our business, and categories such as leather accessories and international ready-to-wear are becoming increasingly important," he said. "For me, growth is not simply about becoming bigger; it is about becoming a more complete luxury house. We are building categories that allow customers to engage with Sabyasachi more frequently, while maintaining the same standards of quality, craftsmanship and integrity that define our culture and jewellery," he added.

The brand is also actively building international ready-to-wear, and the idea is to create global luxury from a Kolkata point of view, said Mukherjee. Some of it will be produced within the brand's own ecosystem, while for certain products it will work with the 'finest' factories and ateliers around the world, he said. "The point is not to imitate global luxury, but to participate in it with a very distinct Indian perspective," he added. He has said he has never believed



SABYASACHI MUKHERJEE Founder, Sabyasachi

Our investment continues to go into building capacity, strengthening product development and protecting and expanding the artisanal ecosystem that makes the brand possible

in entering a category simply because there is a commercial opportunity. "A category needs to feel culturally and aesthetically authentic. Eyewear, for example, has been part of the Sabyasachi language almost from the beginning. We began that journey as a collaboration with Morgenthal Frederics. Now, on our own, we are building eyewear into a much larger category for the House," said Mukherjee.

"We are also aggressively building small leather goods, which I believe will become an important business, particularly for gifting. Fragrance should arrive within the next 18 months, while women's and men's footwear will eventually follow," he added.

Mukherjee said over the last year, the brand has transitioned into new, state-of-the-art manufacturing facilities in Kolkata. "Our investment continues to go into building capacity, strengthening product development and, most importantly, protecting and expanding the artisanal ecosystem that makes the brand possible," he added.

TV Ad Volumes Drop Again in January-July Amid Digital Shift

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: Television advertising volumes per channel declined 7% in January-July 2026 compared with the year-ago period, according to TAM AdEx. The decline follows a 9% fall in January-July 2025 over January-July 2024, marking a second consecutive period of contraction in TV advertising volumes. The pressure on television advertising comes amid a broader shift in the advertising market towards digital. According to the FICCI-EY Media & Entertainment report, linear TV ad revenue declined 10.3% in 2025, driven by a 11.5% drop in ad volumes, as brands allocated higher budgets to point-of-sale advertising and the ban on real money gaming impacted sports. The number of TV advertisers came down by 3% from 2024 to 7,275.

Food & beverages remained the largest advertising sector, accounting for 23% of TV ad volumes, followed by services at 16% and personal care/personal hygiene at 15%. The top 10 sectors together accounted for nearly 90% of ad volumes.

At the category level, toilet soaps led with a 6.3% share, followed by toilet/floor cleaners at 5.9% and ecomm-media/entertainment/social media at 3.8%. Biscuits was the new entrant in the top 10, ranking seventh with a 2.4% share. The top 10 categories accounted for 33% of TV ad volumes.

While overall volumes declined, several categories recorded sharp growth. Ecomm-other services registered the highest increase, with ad volumes rising 10.2 times over January-July 2025, followed by biscuits at 2.1 times. Other hair dressing grew 3.8 times and fitness equipment/clinics 2.9 times. Noodles/pasta rose 67%, while life insurance grew 46%.

FMCG players dominated the advertiser rankings. Reckitt Benckiser (India) moved to No 1, ahead of Hindustan Unilever and Godrej Consumer Products. The top 10 advertisers accounted for 43% of TV ad volumes. GEC remained the largest advertising genre at 30%, followed by news at 25% and movies at 23%. The top five genres accounted for more than 90% of TV ad volumes.

ET Masterclass

ET THE ECONOMIC TIMES BUSINESS VERTICALS

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A TIMES INTERNET INITIATIVE

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Mobile Phone Manufacturing Norms Outlined

PTI

New Delhi: Mobile phone companies, including electronics contract manufacturers, having a turnover of ₹10,000 crore in FY26 will be eligible for benefits under the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme, the government said on Friday.

According to the guidelines of the ₹62,500-crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS) issued on Friday, mobile phone companies, including electronic manufacturing services (EMS) firms with 51% Indian ownership, having a turnover of ₹1,000 crore in FY26 will also be eligible for participation in the scheme.

The scheme has been divided in two parts - incentivising mobile phone manufacturing and supporting Indian mobile phone brands. The MPMS is aimed at providing support in the form of production-linked incentives for manufacturing mobile phones in India.

The tenure of the scheme will be five years starting from the current fiscal year. Applicants with majority Indian ownership can be granted a gestation period of one year, according to the Ministry of Electronics and IT.

Investment in Ecosystems

From Page 1

The Aditya Birla Group is the largest manufacturer of cement in the country, is a leading producer of aluminium and entered the paints business two years back.

All the three businesses are currently seeing heightened competitive intensity.

Birla also said both competition and risk taking are an important part of running a business.

"It is always good to have a view on competition. But I think that we have focused on what we know best, which is running plants, investing deeply into ecosystems," he said. "Our approach has been rather simple. We believe in running our own race."

Birla, 59, who had to take over the group at the age of 28 after his father's untimely death in 1995, spoke with quiet pride about his children - Ananya and Aryaman - who have been taking a greater role in the family business as well as striking out on their own. While he's there for advice and guidance if needed, Birla also prefers to let them find their own way in their chosen individual pursuits.

Services PMI Picks Up in Aug After Hitting 4-Yr Low in July

Services index rises to 54.5; manufacturing PMI declines to 52.9

Bloomberg

India's economic activity edged up in August from a four-year low last month as a pick up in services offset a sharp slowdown in manufacturing, a flash survey by HSBC Holdings PLC showed Friday.

The services purchasing managers' index rose to 54.5 from 53.3 in July, while the manufacturing purchasing managers' index fell to 52.9 from 53.5 last month. That left the composite index at 54.6, up from a more than four-year low of 54.3 in July.

"Although the latest reading signaled a faster expansion of private sector activity, it was the second-



weakest since March 2022," HSBC said in a statement. "Challenging market conditions, competitive pressures and lower customer requirements often stymied growth." The indexes, reflecting business confidence in the economy, are based on preliminary surveys. The data may be revised when final PMI figures are released next month. A reading above 50 indicates expansion in economic activity, while a print below that indicates contraction.

"Overall private sector output growth was broadly steady, helped by stronger services activity," said Pranjal Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC. However, weakened manufacturing meant output and new orders growth was slow and stock of finished goods remained

high, signaling weak demand.

The latest PMI may dampen some enthusiasm about India's economic growth. While fears of a sharp inflation spike have failed to materialize so far, risks do remain, particularly from ongoing tensions in the Middle East and high oil prices. India imports around 90% of its crude oil needs.

For now, officials remain upbeat. The nation could clock growth of close to 7% in the financial year through March, exceeding the Reserve Bank of India's 6.7% forecast, deputy governor Poonam Gupta said at an event in Chennai on Thursday.

Better economic prospects together with inflation risks may keep the central bank on alert. The RBI has kept interest rates unchanged.

Erstwhile Govts Offered Production-Linked Punishment, Not Incentives

From Page 1

Slamming previous dispensations that had penalised production that exceeded prescribed limits, the Prime Minister drew a comparison between "PLP" and "PLI." Under PLP, or production-linked punishment, manufacturing units had to destroy excess output or face government scrutiny. Those criticising his government today belong to that dispensation, he added.

"Those governments wanted people to suffer from shortage so they would come to them with folded hands for their needs," said Modi, adding that this also hampered employment generation.

His regime, on the other hand, promotes production-linked incentives (PLI) that have resulted in Rs 2.5 lakh crore investment, Rs 22 lakh crore production and sales, Rs 15 lakh crore of exports, and creation of more than 1.4 million direct and indirect jobs.

"Today, there is political stability and continuity in policy," Modi said. "Earlier, reforms were announced but not implemented, but we have a clear roadmap of reforms. The direction of these reforms has been that they should be at the governance level.

on NDA Approach

Earlier, the approach was 'prohibited unless permitted,' which meant that until the government gave you permission, you could not do it," Modi said. "We have changed it to 'permitted unless prohibited.' The thinking behind this approach is clear: The basis of the relationship between the government and the people should be trust, not suspicion."

The Prime Minister mentioned the Jan Vishwas Bill, the repeal of 1,500 archaic laws and removal of 40,000 compliances in this regard.

He also underlined the intent behind the Bankers' Book Evidence Bill that was passed amid protests in the much-disrupted monsoon session of Parliament recently.

Modi also listed a number of reforms in railways and the Delhi metro rail, the opening of the nuclear and defence sector, the achievements of the Border Roads Organisation and the growth in digital payments that have eased the life of common people.

It shouldn't be that a policy is made and that the nation is then forced to abide by it. "Today, we are making policies which are pro-people, pro-growth and pro-development," the Prime Minister said. "Policies should be made according to the requirements of a nation."

el. In the 21st century, we are not just changing regulations but also changing the very philosophy of regulations."

The Prime Minister highlighted a key change in the reform thrust.

Centre Rejects Ethanol Link to Sugar Price Rise



New Delhi: The Centre rejected claims that diversion of sugar for ethanol production was driving a rise in sugar prices, saying instead that lower domestic output, festive season demand and hoarding had prompted the government to impose stock limits and allow duty-free imports. The share of sugar diverted for making ethanol for doping in petrol. PTI

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT, FOREST AND CLIMATE CHANGE
NATIONAL AUTHORITY (CAMPA) New Delhi
CORRIGENDUM - EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
Empanelment of Entities for Third-Party Monitoring & Evaluation (TPM&E) of CAMPA-funded Activities and Schemes
National Authority (CAMPA) has issued a corrigendum revising certain eligibility conditions under the EoI.
The last date for submission of applications has been extended to 04 September 2026, 5:00 PM.
Tender ID: 2026_CAMPA_846541_1 | Tender Ref. No.: NA-2/12/2026-NA
For the corrigendum, detailed EoI & M&E Framework, visit: eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app&nationalcampa.nic.in | moef.gov.in
Applicants are advised to refer to the published corrigendum before submission

MULTI-YEAR REVENUE STREAM

Welspun Bags Biggest US Order

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Welspun Corp has secured its largest single order worth ₹17,200 crore or \$1.8 billion for supply of pipes from its US manufacturing facility, the company said on Friday. Its stock surged 15.08% to close at ₹2,306.40 on BSE on Friday.

The order, to be executed in FY28-29, will significantly strengthen the company's order book and provide multi-year revenue visibility, the company said. The latest contract takes Welspun Corp's global order book to a record \$4.4 billion, or about ₹42,100 crore, the company said in a regulatory filing.

Pipes and building materials maker said the order strengthens its position in the North American energy infrastructure market and validates its investments in manufacturing capacity, technology and customer relationships in the region. "North America has been a

strategically important market for us, and we have continued to invest ahead of the curve to strengthen our manufacturing and technological capabilities in the region," said BK Goenka, chairman, Welspun World.

Welspun Corp MD and CEO Vipul Mathur said the order size reflected the strength of its US manufacturing platform and customers' confidence in its ability to execute large and complex projects.

"The North American energy infrastructure market continues to present significant opportunities, and our investments in capacity, technology and customer relationships have positioned us well to capture this growth," Mathur said.

The company said the order is also in line with its strategy of establishing manufacturing capacity closer to customers and investing ahead of demand. Welspun Corp, the flagship firm of Welspun World, has manufacturing facilities in India.

SBI
Digital Banking - Consumer, Corporate Centre, 9th Floor, Plot No. IT-6, News Bhakti Knowledge City, Anand Knowledge Park, New Mumbai - 400 708.
E-mail: finetechyono@sbi.co.in; Website: <https://sbi.bank.in/>; <https://etender.sbi/>
NOTICE INVITING RFP (REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL)
RFP No. Ref: SBI/CC/DB - Consumer/I&SP/RFP/2026-27/02
Applications are invited by State Bank of India from eligible Startups, FinTechs & Digital Capability Partners (DCP), for e2e digital Loan Against Securities (Event ID - 41381).
RFP document will be available on <https://etender.sbi/> from 21.08.2026, 17:00 Hrs.
Place: Navi Mumbai Deputy General Manager (Innovation & Spl. Projects)
Date: 22.08.2026 Digital Banking - Consumer

आईआरईएल (इंडिया) लिमिटेड / IREL (India) Limited
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(A Government of India Undertaking)
CIN : U15100MH1950GOI008187, Website : www.irel.co.in
ISO 9001: 2015, ISO 14001: 2015
Ref: ADVT.NO.IREL/EOI/Q-ILM/2026-27/03
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
IREL (India) Limited invites Expression of Interest (Eoi) (Eol No. EOI-IREL-Q-ILMENITE/2026-27 dated 10.08.2026) for the supply of Q grade Ilmenite for export sales for the period of September 2026 to December 2026. Interested buyers may download Eoi document from <http://irel.co.in> (news section). Any corrigendum to the same shall be hosted on above websites only.
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Inventory-4BHK spacious apartments with modern amenities.
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Last date of submission of EMD: 24.08.2026 E-auction will be held on: 25.08.2026 EMD ₹ 8.33 Cr. Total Sale Value ₹ 416.53 Cr. Reserve Price ₹ 10,999/- per sqft.
For more details, please visit our website: <https://nbccauction.enivida.com> Or 97729 07414

Market Trends

STOCK INDICES		% CHANGE
Nifty 50	24252	0.08
S&P Sensex	77541	0.00

MSCI India	1585	0.06
MSCI EM	4769	1.22
MSCI BRIC	741	0.58
MSCI World	23847	0.10
Nikkei	66016	-0.30
Hang Seng	26009	1.21
Kospi(S.Korea)	6913	0.88
Straits Times	5689	0.30

OIL (\$/BRL)

DUBAI CRUDE

84.08

1.38

Absolute Change

GOLD FUTURES Premium/Discount \$(-97.07)

Comex US (\$/OZ)

MCX India (₹/10Gm)

OPEN 4577.00 160630.00

LAST* 4655.00 161750.00

Prev chg (%) 1.83 1.46

FOREX RATE (₹-₹ Exchange Rate)

OPEN 95.66 LAST* 95.71

*At 6 pm IST

Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ET Data

Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

Short Takes

Nobel Hygiene Files Papers for ₹150-cr IPO

MUMBAI: Nobel Hygiene, manufacturer of diapers and other absorbent hygiene products, has filed its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for an initial public offering (IPO), according to the information on the exchange. The public issue will comprise a fresh issue of equity shares worth ₹150 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of 1.55 crore equity shares by existing shareholders.

Online Instruments Gets Sebi Nod for ₹750-cr IPO

BENGALURU: Audiovisual systems integration company Online Instruments (India) Ltd has received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to go ahead with its proposed initial public offering (IPO), according to the regulator's latest update. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹750 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of 57.1 lakh equity shares by promoters. Meanwhile, Gold India Ltd has withdrawn its IPO application that was filed with Sebi.

Gaja Cap IPO Gets 31x Subscription on Final Day

MUMBAI: The ₹550 crore initial public offering (IPO) of Gaja Capital was subscribed 31.33 times on the final day of bidding. The subscriptions were largely driven by institutional investors. The Qualified Institutional Buyers (QIB) portion was subscribed 43.58 times, while the non-institutional investor (NII) portion was subscribed 62.35 times. The retail portion was subscribed 11.03 times.

Lumino Sets IPO Price Band at ₹78-82/share

MUMBAI: Lumino Industries has fixed the price band for its ₹700 crore initial public offering (IPO) at ₹78-82 per equity share. The IPO will open for subscription on August 27 and close on August 31. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of 6.10 crore shares aggregating to ₹500 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of 2.44 crore shares worth ₹200 crore.

Amagi Media Labs Gains 4% After ₹587cr Block Deal

MUMBAI: Trudy Holdings, Accel Growth VI Holdings (Mauritius), Accel India VI (Mauritius), and AVP I Fund have sold a combined 4.85% stake in Amagi Media Labs in a block deal worth ₹587.3 crore on the NSE on Friday. They sold 1.04 crore shares at ₹560 apiece. Amagi's shares ended 4.1% higher at 599.85 on Friday. SBI MF, HDFC Standard Life Insurance Co, ICICI Prudential MF, Tata MF, Susquehanna Pacific Pfy, Edelweiss MF, and Baroda BNP Paribas MF were some of the buyers. - **Our Bureau**

Fundraise to Help Aditya Info Scan for Fresh Growth

STREET VIEW High component costs a drag, but co has retained Ebitda guidance; Analysts also have a buy call

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Shares of Aditya Infotech, a security and surveillance products manufacturer, have recovered 4% in the past two trading sessions on the news of fresh equity fund raising to expand capacity. It has reduced the fall in the share price to 11% since August 12 when the company declared a sequentially weaker June quarter performance.

Elevated prices of electronic components affected the company's profitability in the June quarter on a sequential basis. Though the company has retained the guidance for operating margin before depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda margin) at 14-15% for FY27, it will be a tough task given the import share

STREET DRIFT Indices end marginally lower for a 2nd week; Nifty likely to trade in 24,000-24,500 band in absence of fresh triggers or oil price fall

West Asia Clouds Linger, Nifty may Stay in Narrow Range

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equity indices ended another week on a subdued note, as geopolitical tensions from West Asia, and higher crude oil prices continued to weigh on Dalat Street. Analysts said that the Nifty could continue to see rangebound moves and trade sideways unless fresh triggers emerge.

NSE's Nifty rose 20.15 points or 0.1% to close at 24,252. BSE's Sensex ended flat at 77,540.83 on Friday. The indices declined 0.5% and 0.6% for the week, respectively, after ending marginally lower in the previous week as well.

"The US-Iran geopolitical tensions continued to weigh on markets this week, resulting in subdued trading and range-bound movements," said Sunny Agrawal, head of research at SBI Securities.

Agrawal said the US Fed's intervention to cool 30-year US bond yields provided some interim relief during the week, while the results season wrapped up far better than expected, with most companies delivering double-digit revenue and PAT growth.

The escalation in geopolitical talks took Brent crude oil futures to over \$94 a barrel on Friday evening, and prices were above the \$90 mark for the entire week.

"We will continue to watch for any positive geopolitical developments or a cooling off in oil prices over the weekend," Agrawal said. "If not, the Nifty is likely to remain in the 24,000-24,500 range and see news flow-driven moves."

Ruchit Jain, head—equity technical research, Motilal Oswal Financial Services, said going ahead, crude remains the market's biggest worry. "If it starts to cool off, the Nifty may soon break past its near-term resistance of 24,500-24,600," he said.

Nifty's Volatility Index rose 4.1% to 11.2 Friday, indicating some caution among market participants. Nifty Midcap 150 gained 0.1% and Nifty Small-cap 250 rose 0.4%. Of the total 4,564 stocks traded on Friday, 2,177 advanced and 2,152 declined at the close. The midcap index

remained flat for the week, while Smallcap 250 rose 0.7%.

"We saw the Nifty recently correct from its recent highs, with the index failing to surpass the previous day's highs for 12 straight sessions," said Jain. "However, mid-week, the index started rising again and has respected its 24,000 support. In every correction since March, the Nifty has formed higher bottoms, which remains a positive sign," he said.

Elsewhere in Asia, Japan fell 0.3%, China remained flat, while Hong Kong rose 1.2%, South Korea gained 0.9% and Taiwan rose 0.7%. The pan-Europe index Stoxx 600 was up 0.2% at the time of going to print. Foreign portfolio investors net sold shares worth ₹543 crore. Domestic institutions were buyers to the tune of ₹2,124 crore.

Stocks on the Move

Nifty 500 Top Weekly Gainers & Losers

GAINERS	CMP (₹)	Weekly Chg (%)	LOSERS	CMP (₹)	Weekly Chg (%)
Welspun Corp	2,312	23.4	Himadri Speciality Chem	654	-16.2
Jyoti CNC Automation	989	19.6	Schneider Electric Infra	1,217	-11.1
Balrampur Chini Mills	729	16.7	NMDC Steel	40	-10.6
Welspun Living	189	15.3	Belrise Industries	232	-9.2
Aegis Logistics	1,418	12.1	CESC	155	-7.6

Compiled by: ET Data Team

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FOR LONG-TERM BETTORS WITH HIGH RISK TOLERANCE

Skyways Top Freight Player, but Vulnerable to Global Turbulence

IPO WATCH

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Skyways Air Services, a logistics company, plans to raise ₹399 crore through a fresh issue to repay debt and fund working capital requirements. It will also raise ₹184 crore through an offer for sale. The promoter group's stake will fall to 56.8% after the IPO from 79.1%. It is a multi-modal logistics provider offering end-to-end supply chain solutions across air and ocean freight forwarding. More than three-fourth of the revenue comes from air freight services. It has heavy dependency on cross-border trade making business susceptible to global economic slowdown, trade policy shifts, and currency volatility. However, it has been No. 1 Air Freight Forwarder since the past four calendar years. Given these factors, the issue is suitable for long-term investors with high risk-tolerance.

BUSINESS

Incorporated in 1984, Skyways Air Services provides services such as air and ocean freight forwarding, trucking, warehousing, custom broking, technology driven express cargo and parcel delivery. According to World ACD, the company has been consistently ranked No. 1 Air Freight Forwarder in terms of air waybills (AWB) from 2022 to 2025. It maintains direct commercial relationships with 56 international airlines and relies on a global network of logistics alliances to serve clients across 12 countries. The company has developed proprietary platforms to support different aspects of logistics operations. Air cargo volume grew close to 84 thousand tonnes in FY26

In a Nutshell

IPO dates	Aug 24-27
IPO price	₹131-138
Issue size	Up to ₹583 cr
Implied market cap	Up to ₹2,005.7 cr
Face value	₹10
Lot size	100
Retail portion	35%

from 48 thousand tonnes in FY24 while ocean containers volume increased to 28,275 TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent unit) from 16,294 TEUs during the period.

FINANCIALS

Between FY24 and FY26, revenue from operations rose 47.7% annually to ₹2,812.9 crore, operating profit before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda) jumped 61.2% to ₹125.6 crore and net profit grew 35.7% to ₹63.5 crore. While Ebitda margin expanded to 4.5% in FY26 from 3.8% in FY24, it trails peers whose margins range between 5% and 7.8%. In contrast, the company's net profit margin of 2.3%, is towards the higher end of the peer range of 0.2-2.7%. Cash flow from operations grew to ₹113.6 crore in FY26 from a deficit ₹9 crore in FY24.

VALUATION

Considering the post-IPO equity and net profit for FY26, the company demands a price-earnings (P/E) multiple of upto 32. For peers including TVS Supply Chain Solutions, Shadowfax Technologies, Delhivery and Mahindra Logistics, the P/E range is wider between 46 and 376.

Karur Vysya Raises MCLR by Up to 25 bps

MUMBAI: Karur Vysya Bank on Friday announced a rise in its marginal cost of funds based lending rates (MCLR) by up to 25 basis points. The rise was steepest for the one-month MCLR at 9% from 8.75%. The overnight MCLR would also be 9% against 8.85%. The MCLR for three-month will now be 9.15% against 8.95%, six-month will be 9.30% against 9.15% and one year will be 9.40% from 9.35%. The new rates are applicable from August 22, the bank said.

GOLDMAN BEGINS COVERAGE Brokerage sees up to 37% upside; ICICI and Kotak top picks

‘Pvt Banks to Lead Way as Earnings Recover’

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Goldman Sachs has initiated coverage on 14 Indian banks, with ICICI Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank emerging as its top picks. The brokerage sees up to 37% upside across its coverage, as it expects the banking sector to enter a cyclical earnings recovery supported by healthy loan growth, improving liquidity, recovering net interest margins (NIMs) and benign asset quality.

Goldman Sachs initiated Buy ratings on ICICI Bank with a target price of ₹1,935, implying 37% upside, and Kotak Mahindra Bank at ₹509, implying 31% upside.

It also initiated HDFC Bank at ₹861, implying a 19% upside, Axis Bank at ₹1,477 with 19% upside, Federal Bank at ₹425 with 19% upside and AU Small Finance Bank at ₹1,270 with 18% upside.

The brokerage initiated Neutral ratings on IndusInd Bank, IDFC First Bank, Bandhan Bank and State Bank of India. It set target prices of ₹1,020 for IndusInd Bank, ₹92 for IDFC First Bank, ₹180 for Bandhan Bank and ₹1,170 for SBI.

Goldman Sachs said the earnings recovery at mid-sized private banks is already reflected to a large extent in valuations, while further re-rating would require sustained RoEs above the cost of equity.

On the 'Sell' side, Goldman Sachs initiated RBL Bank with a target

price of ₹285, implying 26% downside, while Yes Bank was assigned a target of ₹22, implying 2.1% downside. Bank of Baroda and Punjab National Bank were also initiated at Sell, with target prices of ₹245 and ₹103, respectively.

Goldman Sachs expects private banks to outperform state-owned banks over the next two years on loan growth, NIMs and asset quality. It expects private banks to accelerate loan growth above system levels, supported by stronger FCNRR(B) deposit mobilisation and a recovery in unsecured lending as asset-quality concerns ease. The brokerage expects system loan growth to remain at around 14-15% during FY26-FY29E, while deposit growth is expected to accelerate as liquidity improves.

NIMs are expected to trough over the next two quarters before gradually recovering. It also expects asset quality to remain benign, with stress largely confined to granular unsecured loans.

DEADLINE RUSH

Banks Ride RBI Swap Wave to Raise \$12b via Overseas Debt

Lenders set to rake in more funds before window for special forex deposits closes on Aug 31

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: Indian banks have already raised an eye-popping \$12 billion abroad this year, taking advantage of the central bank's one-time swap facility, and global appetite for top-notch local banking papers should help lenders raise even more funds at competitive rates ahead of the August 31 deadline for special forex deposits, bankers said.

Overall, \$17 billion of total debt raised in 2026 from India is on track to surpass the \$22 billion garnered in 2021 — and dwarfs the \$5 billion raised in 2025.

This week was the busiest for forex debt issuance by Indian lenders. ICICI Bank, Kotak Mahindra Bank, IDFC First Bank, HDFC Bank and Bank of Baroda together raised a massive \$4.4 billion, and the bulk of the proceeds may be used to help fund the leverage for foreign currency non-resident (bank) [FCNR (B)] deposits.

FCNR-B deposits booked by August 31 qualify for the swap support.

HDFC Bank raised \$1.75 billion Thursday, the largest by any Indian bank, in an issue that followed the \$750 million the country's most-valued lender had raised in June. IDFC First and BoB both up-sized their previous issues adding \$100 million and \$400 million, respectively, on Friday as banks continued to pile up the cash.

Arup Rakshit, head, treasury,

Journey So Far

HDFC Bank, said the funds raised would underpin leverage to clients and also help fund customers abroad. "The amounts raised by the sector shows the strength of Indian banking," Rakshit said.

"The demand for our bonds is an endorsement for HDFC Bank's credit quality," he said.

Of the \$12 billion raised by banks, \$10 billion was garnered after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced on June 5 the special dispensation for drawing deposits and other forex-inflow programmes.

TIGHT SPREADS

But the apparent supply glut from India hasn't come at a steep cost. Vinod Venkatesh, co-head, financing solutions, HSBC India,

Bank bond supply may fall after swap expiry

Heavy bond supply barely widened borrowing spreads

Strong credit quality sustaining global investor appetite

Overall, \$17 billion of total debt raised in 2026 from India is on track to surpass the \$22 billion garnered in 2021

ny now see this as a rare window of opportunity to add exposure to the Indian banking sector," Venkatesh said.

DOLLAR SURGE Holdings hit \$716.9 b after seven weeks of gains

Forex Reserves Grow \$50 b Since July on FCNR Boost

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: India's foreign exchange reserves surged by nearly \$50 billion since July as inflows swelled into the banks' foreign currency non-resident bank (FCNR-B) following the Reserve Bank of India's measures to attract dollars.

The forex stockpile rose \$9.905 billion in the week to August 14 taking the kitty to \$716.90 billion, RBI data showed, marking the seven consecutive weekly rise.

The country's forex stockpile jumped by \$49.975 billion in the past seven weeks as inflows poured into FCNR-B deposits of local banks. Foreign currency assets, the largest component of the reserves, rose \$7.2 billion to \$581.85 billion, making the biggest contribution to the overall increase.

Meanwhile, gold reserves surged by \$2.67 billion to \$111.41 billion, providing another boost.

Indian banks have received about \$53 billion through the special FCNR-B deposit mobilisation scheme till August 14 while another \$4.5 billion through external

commercial borrowing (ECB) and overseas foreign currency borrowing (OFCB) by banks, the Reserve Bank of India data showed. Governor Sanjay Malhotra said that the central bank is anticipating around \$80 billion inflows.

The Reserve Bank of India has advanced the scheme deadline a month to August 31 since the inflows were more than anticipated. The swap window for FCNR-B deposits will remain open till September 11. The scheme for ECBs and OFCBs will continue to be open till December 31, 2026, as announced earlier.

The swap, whereby Reserve Bank of India absorbs the annual 280-300 basis point hedging cost for banks, helped the central bank raise its foreign currency assets, people aware said.

Rupee Ends Flat as Early Scheme Closure Weighs

KOLKATA: The rupee closed nearly unchanged at 95.6950 against the US dollar on Friday, moving in a tight range following the previous close of 95.70.

Traders are not taking any fresh positions before the early close of the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) window, said people tracking the currency market. "It's a flat market as nobody was willing to take any fresh position while the regulator continued its intervention," said a forex dealer, who did not wish to be named.

The rupee rose to 95.64 but retreated to the 95.6950 level amid pressure from the rise in global crude prices.

Bond Yield Hits 2-Month High as Rate Hike Looms

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The yield on the 10-year benchmark rose to 6.88% Friday, making it a new two-month high, before cooling off to settle lower at 6.85% as sentiment turned cautious on account of the anticipation of a policy rate hike as well as the fresh escalation of the West Asia conflict.

Traders started factoring a rate tightening in the third quarter following an unexpected hawkish minutes of the monetary policy meeting.

The yield jumped 9.5 basis points during the week, making it the highest weekly rise this fiscal, following the hawkish

"The monetary policy appeared dovish. But it changed to hawkish after the minutes came out where MPC members spoke about the possibility of a rise in rate in December," Karur Vysya Bank treasury head Rama Chandra Reddy said. "The fresh escalation of the geopolitics also weighed on the sentiment," he said.

performance on a sequential basis. As a result, the stock fell after it reported nearly 16% fall in net profit and 330 basis point contraction in Ebitda margin for June quarter against the previous quarter.

In response to rising input costs, the company raised product prices by 15-20%, which was lower than the FY27 indicative raise of 25%. Its efforts to source components locally would take two-three quarters to affect the financials meaningfully.

The latest qualified institutional placement worth ₹1,500 crore to increase capacity looks timely since the current capacity utilisation is 85-90% thereby improving revenue visibility amid sustained demand scenario. Analysts have a 'buy' call on the stock with a 10-20% upside from Friday's closing price of ₹3,476.3.

Key Metrics

Quarterly Performance of Aditya Infotech (₹ crore)

	Jun'26	Mar'26	QoQ Chg (%)
Revenue	1,402	1,422	-1.4
EBITDA	208	258.3	-19.6
EBITDA Margin (%)	14.8	18.1	-330 bps
Net Profit	142	169.1	-15.9

Bps: Basis points (100 bps = 1% point). EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax depreciation and amortisation

SOURCE: Company data, ETIG

latory norms. In FY26, revenue grew by 35.6% to ₹4,220.8 crore while Ebitda grew by 124% to ₹579 crore and net profit shot up by 165.7% to ₹492.7 crore. The strong growth percolated to its stock performance, with 128% gain in 2026 so far. Its market cap has shot up to ₹41,124

crore as on Friday from ₹7,900 crore at the time of its initial public offering (IPO) last July while the price-earnings multiple has expanded to 86 from 68 during the period. Such a rapid jump in the stock and valuations has prompted investors to track the company's

Iran Vows ‘Devastating’ Response as US Threatens Toughest-ever Economic Hit

US treasury chief Scott Bessent says more detail to come on Monday; oil prices edge lower

Dubai | Washington: Iran said on Friday that its response to any new US threats would be “devastating” after Washington pledged to impose the toughest financial penalties in history with the aim of toppling the Iranian leadership.

Washington prepared for sanctions that US Treasury chief Scott Bessent said he would detail on Monday. President Donald Trump earlier warned of economic consequences against any country that provided “any type of lifeline to Iran.”

The chief of staff of Iran’s Armed Forces, Major General Ali Abdollahi, said the Islamic Republic’s reaction would be broad and decisive.

“With preparedness across land, sea, air, air defence and cyberspace, Iran’s armed forces will respond to the enemy’s new threats with crushing, punishing and devastating responses,” Abdollahi was quoted as saying by Iranian media.

Iran’s parliament speaker, Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, the country’s main negotiator in mediated talks with the United States, said Washington appeared to have concluded it could not prevail in its direct military confrontation.

“We must make plans to deal with the unjust sanctions so that we can overcome them,” he said in neighbouring Iraq, accusing the US and Israel of resorting to what he said was economic and “cognitive” warfare.



Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf stands with Iraq’s PMF members at the grave of Iraqi commander Abu Mahdi al-Muhandis

TRAFFIC PLUMMETS



Just seven commodity ships sailed along the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday, half the previous day’s tally, data showed

term referring to military force.

Thousands of people have been killed in the war, which has drawn in Gulf nations and raised global fuel prices as Iran has attacked shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, which before February carried about a fifth of all traded oil.

Just seven commodity ships sailed along the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday, half the previous day’s tally, data from shiptracker Kpler showed, compared with more than 130 a day before the war.

Bessent told CNBC he would “talk about exactly what we’re going to

do” on Iran at a press conference on Monday. “We are going to collapse this regime. It is time for our allies and the rest of the world to make a decision,” he said, describing a naval blockade reimposed on Iran in July and the “toughest sanctions in history” as a “one-two punch.”

Iran has weathered near-continuous economic sanctions for nearly 50 years, since the Islamic Revolution of 1979, but its people are suffering high inflation, a weakening currency and energy shortages along with damaged infrastructure.

Some Iranians interviewed by Reu-

Ukraine Allies to Meet on Monday

Countries allied with Ukraine in its war with Russia will meet on Monday to reaffirm support for Kyiv, in talks held on Ukraine’s independence day, the French presidency said Friday.

The meeting of the Coalition of the Willing will be co-chaired by French President Emmanuel Macron -- joining via video link -- German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and the new British Prime Minister Andy Burnham, the Elysee Palace said. Around 10 leaders including European Council chief Antonio Costa will be in Kyiv for the coalition meeting, according to an EU official. —AFP

ters have said more economic punishment could increase hardship, weaken the clerical establishment and prompt unrest, although there has been no sign of that since a deadly crackdown on protests in January.

Before Bessent spoke, Iran’s foreign ministry said US sanctions would not “create even the slightest hesitation in Iranians’ determination.”

Trump is under pressure to end the war, with high fuel prices dragging down his approval ratings and potentially threatening his Republican Party’s control of Congress in midterm elections. —Reuters

‘MEASURES SHOULD NOT DRIVE UP OIL’

Oil prices edged lower on Friday but were on track for a second weekly rise after rising on Thursday following the new US sanctions threat.

“I’m not sure why oil has popped up on this,” Bessent told CNBC. “If we are doing the maximum economic pressure, then that means that likely there will not be a large-scale kinetic restart,” he said, using a

OBITUARY

Nancy Kissinger, Wife of Ex-US Secy of State, Dies at 92

Nancy Kissinger, who transformed from a foreign policy specialist into a force beside her diplomat husband, Henry, and helped cement their place among New York’s social elite, has died. She was 92.

She died at her home in South Kent, Connecticut, the New York Times reported, citing an announcement from her family.

In her travels with her husband, who served as US secretary of state under Presidents Richard Nixon and Gerald Ford, Nancy Kissinger evoked the elegance of former first lady Jackie Kennedy. At almost 6 feet tall, with a ready wit, lithe figure, patrician manners and Episcopal rearing, she was an intriguing foil to her 5-foot-8 husband, who’d fled Nazi Germany at age 15. No one was ever bored when seated next to her.

She met Mao Zedong in China and Mother Teresa in India and visited Harry Truman’s widow, Bess, in Independence, Missouri. The leader of the Kurdish rebels in Iraq gave her a gold and pearl necklace. King Hussein of Jordan flew her in his helicopter. —Bloomberg

ASIA’S FINANCIAL HUBS COMPETE FOR MONEY MANAGERS

Hedge Fund Stars Spark Race to Cut Taxes in HK, Singapore

On Wednesday evening, as most of Singapore’s workers headed home, several of its leading financiers crowded into a Sofitel Hotel ballroom. The guest of honour was Chee Hong Tat, the Monetary Authority of Singapore’s deputy chairman. The topic du jour: slashing the taxes paid by hedge fund stars and other managers.

For months, Hong Kong has been openly courting the brightest minds in money management.

Its most eye-catching move was introducing legislation that would erase the levies on carried interest — a shift that could be worth millions of dollars a year for high earners.

This week, Singapore fired back.

At a closed-door talk in the Wallis Ballroom and hosted by the MAS’s Singapore Financial Leaders Network, a platform for the city’s finance sector leaders to network with peers and government officials, Chee spoke at length about what Singapore was doing to boost its appeal to asset management firms, according to a person familiar with the matter.

The details shared didn’t go far beyond what had already been released five hours earlier via the press. But that short statement — which pledged tax exemptions that could potentially go even further than Hong Kong — has set Singapore’s finance community alight. It sparked furious activity among the WhatsApp groups of fund managers and a barrage of



calls to tax consultants from companies and individual portfolio managers, said people familiar, who asked not to be identified.

The move is the latest chapter in a long-running battle for firms and people between Singapore and Hong Kong, which each boast asset management industries worth more than \$5 trillion.

The exact details are still unclear and Chee told the gathered finance leaders on Wednesday night that more would be revealed at the next annual budget, which typically takes place in February. But what is clear is that asset managers in Asia are now entering a new era, with intensifying competition between financial hubs promising a windfall for some of the financial industry’s biggest earners.

“Hong Kong moved quickly and proposed tax rules to stay competitive,” said Will Tan, managing partner at Principle Partners, a search firm with offices in Singapore and Hong Kong. “Singapore has decided it needs to move as

well to stay ahead.”

Singapore’s core proposal is to exempt a share of profits made by fund managers and investment professionals when they deliver “strong returns” for investors in qualifying funds — a move that appears to match Hong Kong’s recently announced plan to slash taxes on carried interest.

Several executives at Singapore-based hedge funds said the move already had an immediate impact, helping delay demands from some staff to move to Hong Kong. With 2027 applications for international schools often closing by November, many portfolio managers with families were under pressure to make decisions soon.

Some fund managers who were in the process of reorganising their operations and the locations of their top employees from Singapore to Hong Kong are now rethinking the decision, according to a tax adviser who asked not to be identified. “It gives people reason to pause and at least wait for further details,” said Quantedge Capital Pte Chief Executive Officer Suhaimi Zainul-Abidin, whose Singapore-based hedge fund managed \$7.2 billion as of July.

But other hedge fund executives said it was far too early to conclude which city would win. One told Bloomberg it was impossible for firms and professionals to say how much better off they were until the details emerged. —Bloomberg

Dutch Watchdog Imposes \$966m Penalty on Uber

Amsterdam: The Dutch Data Protection Authority (AP) has decided to fine Uber €825 million (\$966 million) under European data protection rules for deactivating driver accounts through automated systems without adequately informing them, according to an August 17 decision reviewed by Reuters.

The penalty would be the second-largest ever issued under Europe’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), behind a €1.2 billion fine imposed on Meta by Ireland in 2023, which Meta is appealing.

Uber said it would also appeal.

“We strongly disagree with this decision and disproportionate fine,” a spokesperson said, adding that the company takes drivers’ rights seriously and its current policies include both human reviews and opportunities for drivers to dispute platform suspensions.

The AP confirmed the decision, but could not immediately comment further.

GDPR rules ban decisions made solely by computer algorithm when they have a significant impact on people’s lives, saying such decisions require meaningful human review and a way to challenge a decision.

“The AP has determined that Uber violated drivers’ rights, specifically the right not to be subject to automated decision-making that has... significant consequences,” the decision said.

“Uber has also violated the right to be informed,” the decision said, —Reuters

MACRO WATCH

Economists Boost US Growth Forecasts for Third Quarter

GDP now expected to grow at a 2.5% annualised rate

Economists raised their forecasts for US economic growth in the third quarter, reflecting upward adjustments to consumer spending as well as private investment that includes capital outlays on artificial intelligence.

Gross domestic product is now seen expanding at a 2.5% annualised rate in the third quarter, up from 2% in the previous survey, according to the latest Bloomberg News monthly survey of economists. Quarterly GDP projections through the end of 2027 were little changed and confined to a narrow 2%-2.2% range.

Economists also made few adjustments to their inflation projections through next year. The personal consumption expenditures price index, excluding food and energy, is seen averaging 3.2% this year before cooling to an average 2.5% in 2027 on an annual basis.

With the so-called core PCE price metric showing moderating inflation, economists expect the Fed-



TRILLION-DOLLAR RUSH

Total capital expenditures related to artificial intelligence may exceed \$1 trillion this year and \$1.5 trillion in 2027

ral Reserve will keep interest rates unchanged through July of next year.

“Tech/AI related investment is the main factor driving higher bu-

business capex, while high-income household spending is responsible for the majority of consumer spending growth,” said James Knightley, chief international economist at ING.

According to Bloomberg Industry analysts, total capital expenditures related to artificial intelligence may exceed \$1 trillion this year and \$1.5 trillion in 2027.

In addition, “cooler jobs and inflation data and a sense new Fed Chair Kevin Warsh has less inclined to raise rates has seen pricing become less aggressive, with a September hike now seen as less than a 50% call,” Knightley said.

An escalation in the Iran war poses a risk to the outlook by threatening to push oil and consumer prices higher while potentially weighing on growth. With inflation above the Fed’s 2% target, an extended supply shock would make policymakers’ job harder.

Economists also trimmed their estimates for average payroll growth this year to 66,000 a month and see similar monthly job growth in 2027. The Bloomberg survey of as many as 85 economists was conducted August 14-19. —Bloomberg

PMI SIGNALS New orders scale 40-month high; exports resume growth after four-year slump

Euro Zone Business Activity Hits Fastest Pace Since November

Euro zone business activity is growing at its fastest pace this year thanks to stronger new orders, particularly in manufacturing, and renewed export growth, according to business surveys which also showed easing price pressures. Overall, the S&P Global flash PMI surveys for August released on Friday suggested the 21-country economic bloc has remained resilient this quarter despite disruptions from the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran, after expanding 0.4% in the second quarter.

S&P Global’s Flash Euro zone Composite PMI Output Index reached its highest since November this month, edging up to 52.1 from 52.0 in July, beating a Reuters poll forecast of 51.7. Readings above 50 indicate growth.

Final data have come out better than the initial flash readings for the past five months, suggesting the PMI may even be higher by the end of the month.

New orders, a key gauge of demand, have risen at their fastest rate in 40 months, while export orders, which include trade between euro zone nations, have increased for the first time since Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022.

“So far, the impact (of the Iran war) has been far from devastating... the euro zone economy has been quite resilient so far, and momentum remains surprisingly decent. The third quarter seems set for a decent GDP growth print again, firmly ignoring current events,” said Bert Colijn at ING. Colijn said, “with oil above \$90 per barrel again and interest rates having repriced higher in recent weeks, the factors slowing growth and pushing up inflation for the months ahead are clear.” The fac-



tory PMI has risen this month to a more than four-year high of 52.8 from 51.9, beating the poll estimate of 51.8. Output growth has hit its strongest level in 54 months.

Services activity has held steady after July’s rebound, with the PMI unchanged at 51.7, defying forecasts for a slowdown. Activity in Germany, the bloc’s largest economy, has expanded modestly as an upturn in manufacturing offset a sharper decline in services activity. However, in France, activity has contracted more than expected as recent heatwaves hit the country’s dominant services sector. Separate data for Britain showed growth has hit a four-month high on a bigger-than-expected rise in services activity despite a slowdown in factory expansion.

Employment in the common currency bloc has risen for the first time this year as manufacturers resumed hiring after more than three years, while services employment has grown at the fastest pace in eight months.

Price pressures, although still high, have continued to ease, with input cost growth at its slowest in six months and output price inflation easing to a five-month low. —Reuters

COS, SHOPPERS SPEND BIG

UK Private Sector Defies Slowdown Fears, PMI Shows

Britain’s private sector expanded at the fastest pace in four months, as sunny weather and a strong service sector prompted households and businesses to turn on the spending taps.

S&P Global’s purchasing managers’ index rose to 52.5 in August, up from 52.2 last month and above the 51.6 expected by economists.

While economists had expected a slowdown in the third quarter after a bumper first half of 2026, the reading suggested growth is largely holding up with any reading above 50 signaling an expansion.

Recent data has shown the economy is withstanding headwinds from higher energy prices and uncertainty posed by the arrival of new Prime Minister Andy Burnham. Figures released earlier on Friday by GfK showed consumer confidence rising to its highest in two years, the latest sign of sentiment seeing a Burnham bounce.

Chris Williamson, chief business economist at S&P Global Market Intelligence, said the PMI pointed to growth of 0.3% in the third quarter — a pace that would comfortably beat the 0.1% penciled in by economists.

Burnham and Chancellor of the Exchequer John Healey would get a major boost if the UK economy holds on to its first half momentum, ahead of their crucial first budget in the autumn. Output expanded 1% in the first half of 2026, outpacing the US and European peers. —Bloomberg

China Plans Fiscal Support Policies Amid Dip in Growth

Aims to revive domestic demand, expand private spending

China is doubling down on a targeted programme that’s tapping fiscal resources to drive borrowing by businesses and consumers, with new measures set for launch in the rest of the year as economic growth veers below the government’s annual target.

“We’ve been studying and drafting new coordinated fiscal and financial policies that will be introduced in the second half of this year,” vice finance minister Liao Min said at a briefing in Beijing on Friday.

The announcement marks the latest attempt by the government to provide fiscal support for the economy during one of its weakest stretches in years. It also underscores the focus by the authorities on acting carefully to revive domestic demand and expand private spending against the backdrop of mounting fiscal strains at the local level.

In his remarks, Liao was referring to the programme introduced earlier this year that provided perks, including discounted lending backed by fiscal subsidies to companies and consumers, alongside loan guarantees to spur private investment.

The creation of the programme is “one of the key pillars of this year’s more proactive fiscal policy,”



Liao said, adding the authorities will in the future make such fiscal and financial coordination a regular feature of their approach.

When unveiled in January, the subsidy incentives for households and companies were backed with 100 billion yuan (\$15 billion) from the central budget. The effort has been expanded since August 1 to make more types of loans eligible for the interest rate subsidies meant for small and micro businesses and consumers. The package supported more than 20 trillion yuan in new lending during the first seven months of the year, an increase of 4.5% from 2025.

Government data published earlier in the week showed China’s industrial output, consumption and investment all softened more than expected in July.

Pressure on policymakers to step up stimulus is on the rise, given many economists estimate gross domestic product growth has slipped further below Beijing’s annual target of 4.5%-5% after reaching only 4.3% in the second quarter.

Still, Liao suggested the Chinese government’s bond quota already planned for this year is sufficient to ensure it will maintain “fiscal spending intensity,” noting there is more than 2 trillion yuan in the allowance available in the coming months.

The ministry of finance will guide local governments to issue the bonds, accelerate fiscal spending and strengthen oversight of regions whose pace of expenditure has been slow, he said. —Bloomberg



After the change of sides, Zhang and Jia carried their momentum into the



The contest remained tight, with the score reaching 15-14 at one stage. Treesa and Gayatri then produced

"I think we were constantly telling each other it's not over yet, it's not over yet. Because we had a huge lead in the third set, but we just kept telling each other it wasn't over yet," Gavatri said.

Bayern sporting director Max Eberl said the club knew about the condition for over a year and said it was Musiala's decision to go public. **AFP**



of personal feelings. Tomorrow will be the first time the players

Mourinho said he had also drawn a line under the changing-room fight between Aurelien Tchouameni and Federico Valverde late last season, saying both players had convinced him there was no need for peace talks.

become a shareholder in the club and would not play against Reggiana on Monday in the Serie C season opener. **AFP**



While storm names are designed to be memorable and simple, they are not necessarily trying to elicit feelings. Neither were military operation names, which functioned to maintain secrecy and to differentiate one from another until British Prime Minister Winston Churchill changed the nomenclature to suit the broader aims of the allies in World War II.



...causing "obvious public-affairs problems," while the U.S. invasion of Panama being "Operation Just Cause" showed how an operation name could be "deliberately framed for legitimacy," he said. —AP

Even though more desis today know about excellent Indian products—thanks partly to Geographical Indicator (GI) tags or endorsements from the Prime Minister—we are a long way from the lev-

Yet, in taste tests, Indian produce often comes out on top. Besides Tellicherry pepper and Lakadong turmeric, morels (gucchi) from Kashmir come to mind. They are definitive-

...I popped into a well-known gourmet store; it was full of mostly imported goods. Specialty stores do retail great artisanal local produce in many Indian cities: there's one near my Kolkata home that sells amazing heirloom Bengali rice, ghee, spices etc. But none curate and sell top-notch gourmet produce from all over India under one roof. It's time for some desi Harrods Food Halls.

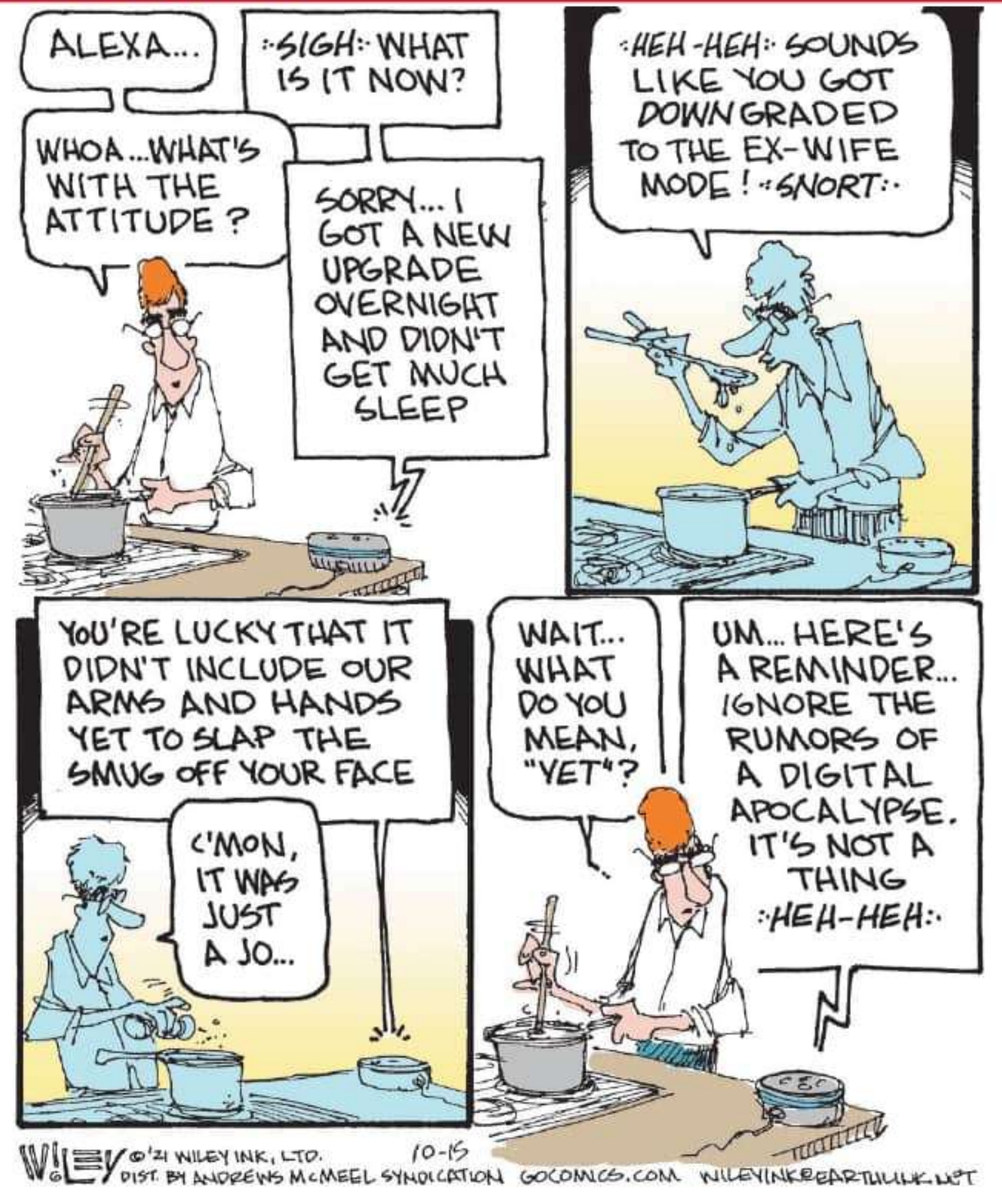
ACROSS

- 1 Ordinary family on holiday cut short in Japanese islands (7)
- 5 Shrewd military personnel in court close to armory (6)
- 9 Element ending in dingy workplace (7)
- 10 Recover with Virginia amid stormy gales (7)
- 11 English river has charm at odd points (3)
- 12 Bachelor helps to cover round with performing musicians (11)
- 13 Libertine linked to northern French city (5)

25 Some cheap hostel's
Vietnamese soup (3)

SOLUTION To No. 9683:
ACROSS: 1 Fire station. 9 Honesty. 10 Undated. 11 Lam.
 12 Deceive. 13 Ignores. 14 Sai.
 15 Mufti. 17 Salep. 18 Ingot.
 20 Remit. 22 Ida. 24 Jackpot.
 25 Courage. 26 Ada. 27 Riotous.
 28 Rotates. 29 Leaseholder.
DOWN: 1 Finishing school.
 2 Rostrom. 3 Style. 4 Alu-
 minium. 5 Indents. 6 Natural
 disaster. 7 Shades. 8 Adds up.
 16 Forestate. 18 Injury.
 19 Tapioca. 21 Trusted. 23 Age-
 ism. 25 Cargo.

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► Banks Ride RBI's One-time Swap Wave to Raise \$12 B via Overseas Debt This Year: P8 ► Welspun Bags its Biggest Order, at ₹17kcr, for Pipe Supply: P7



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